
THE ARKUN CYCLE
STOLEN BREATH
J.D. ALFARO

THE ARKUN CYCLE — BOOK ONE

Stolen Breath

A Biopunk Romantasy Novel

"He was engineered to kill. She was bred to survive.
One breathless touch that changes the sky forever."

BY J.D. ALFARO

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Stolen Breath

The Arkun Cycle — Book One

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MATURE READER GUIDANCE

RATED 18+ FOR ADULT AUDIENCES

Stolen Breath is a high-heat biopunk romantasy written for mature audiences. It contains explicit, descriptive sexual encounters (open door), graphic fantasy violence, biological body horror, trauma recovery, high-stakes peril, and strong language. Reader discretion is advised.

FOR ZUNI

To the one who makes every breath in my life count.

I hope you find my devotion and love between these lines.

Forever will never be enough to share this life with you.



CHAPTER 1

REN

> ***The long pass.*** *The guard's slow walk from the corner back to the gate. They timed it at seven minutes and most of another.*

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Silt ticks on the zinc over Mercer's door and sticks in the cloth I pulled up for the walk. Faces under it are bare. The wall is the whole end of the street, a hundred meters of metal with the dome's light leaking on the top edge, and the south gate is a red cluster too far down to be our problem until we decide it is. A cart argues with a woman about a price. Nobody pays it. I take the clinic stair two at a time because the other stair had a prowler on it at noon, and T.J. said so before I left.

That is the whole trick of a day out here. He watches. I don't walk into what he watched.

Drew is at the bench in the back, dark hair cut at the jaw, the burn across her left hand smeared with grease she hasn't bothered to clean. A dead keypad sits in the vise. The tang of Tsune's Bodkin is in Drew's fingers, dark metal, smaller than the blade she took off it.

"You're late," Drew says.

"I took the cistern alley. The slip got there. She paid in bread and a corner of roof, and she asked when the sweep comes back. I told her I don't sell tomorrow."

"You sell today. Sit."

I sit. The breath catches on the way down, a dry scrape I pretend is the stair. Drew hears it. She does not make it a conversation. The cup she puts by my hand is hot. I drink.

Tsune comes in from the lane without a sound I can use. Collar up, charcoal tunic, shoulders bare, the slate dark on the harness and the hooks quiet at her hips. Amber goggles over her eyes. The braid is tight, and the rest of the Bodkin is still seated in it, a steel line through the hair. Silt has stuck to the scales on her shoulder. She brushes them with a glove like they are weather. I have seen what the collar hides. I do not look at the collar.

"Roof was clean," she says. "Ren."

"Here."

"You ran the alley."

"T.J. called the stair dirty. I listened."

She nods once. That is the praise I get, and it is enough. She pulls the goggles down onto the collar and looks at the keypad in the vise, not at me.

"Talk," she says.

T.J. is already in the room, which means the set on the bench is live and he is under a street he will not come up from. Young voice. Close to the mic. "Twelve long passes. Same boots, same corner, same lazy turn back to the gate. Seven point eight from the corner to the mouth. The camera on that door looks at the gantry joint. It does not look at the keypad."

"And the wire," Tsune says.

"Already mine. I use it for the gate paint. You seat a jack in that keypad and the picture comes down the door's own wire. I read it here. You hold still and the copy sits in your slate. I don't need you to look at a screen. I need the jack to stay seated."

Drew turns the tang so the contacts catch the lamp. "It matches the scrap. A live door will take it or it will scream. I can't promise which until you ask it."

"We have asked prowlers," Tsune says. "We have caught a broadcast when somebody got lazy on an open set. We have not put a jack in a door that is still on the wall."

"That's the point," Drew says. "Prowlers tell us where a truck is. A broadcast tells us what a fool said. The security net tells us which doors

they walk and which cameras are dead. I can shut this clinic for the hour that matters, instead of for the hour I guess."

I know that hour. Last month the guess was wrong and Mercer spent it with the lamp off and a hand on a boy's mouth. Nobody has told him about the door. He is in the front, boiling something that smells like the lane. If this works, he gets a quieter night and a lie about how we knew.

"I can stand at the keypad," I say.

Tsune looks at me then. Not unkind. Finished.

"You can stand on the roof that sees the corner. You count the boots. If the pass breaks the habit, you say it in the same breath. You do not come to the door. A second body on that gantry is a picture, and a picture paints this room."

"Drew could..."

"Drew stays at the bench," Drew says. "The tang is the job. The door is hers. The count is yours. T.J. doesn't get a vote about coming up, because he isn't coming up."

"Correct," T.J. says.

I want the door anyway. I want to be the one close enough to pull her off a gantry if the keypad screams early. She has already done the wanting for me and thrown it out. I put the want on the floor with the silt I tracked in.

"Seven point eight," I say. "If I lose the count, you pull."

"If you lose the count, I already pulled." She takes the tang from Drew and seats the blade back onto it with a twist I have watched a hundred times. The Bodkin goes through the braid until the steel sits against her skull. "We go at the silt, while the gate is in love with its own truck. Ren, roof. You call the corner boot and then you call nothing else unless the number changes."

"Copy."

Mercer coughs in the front room, an old sound, not mine. Tsune kills the bench lamp. Drew wraps the dead keypad in a rag and puts it under the bench, where a man boiling water will not ask what it is. I pull the cloth back up. The lane is the same copper street I came in on. The wall

has not moved. People are buying the last of the day before the night gets cold enough to push them indoors.

I take the roofs instead of the stair. The prowler is still a rumor on the gate road, which is T.J.'s problem and not mine until he says the word. From the third roof I can see the corner and the long empty walk back to the red cluster. The service door is a plain slab in the dark between those lights, with a gantry under it and no guard standing on it.

She comes along that gantry small, collar up, one hand on the hook. She does not look at my roof. She doesn't have to. I have the set against my mouth and the number in my teeth, and the boots have not hit the corner yet.

When they do, I will tell her. Until then I keep still, and I count the habit we are about to spend.

CHAPTER 2

TSUNARI

> ***The service door.*** *A keypad off the south gate, on the wall's own wire. The wire stays open while the jack is seated.*

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The door smells of hot copper and wet rust.

It sits on the outer face, well off the south gate, a plain slab with a keypad at chest height and a gantry under my boots. The wall is cold where my shoulder touches it. The high collar of my tunic is stuck to my throat. Below, Sector 09 ticks. Silt on zinc. A cart. Somebody shouting a price and nobody paying it. The main gate is a red cluster to my left, lights and a truck and every gun they bothered to mount. This door is the dark between those lights.

"Last boot was the long pass," Ren says in my ear. His breath catches on the last word, the dry sound he pretends is only the climb. "Seven point eight from then. I'm on the roof that sees the corner. Drew stayed at the bench."

"Copy." I work the Bodkin out of the braid. A twist, and the blade comes off in my glove. The tang under it is dark, cut for a jack Drew measured off a dead keypad. "T.J."

"Here." Young. Close to the mic. He never is anywhere else. "I have the door's wire. You seat it, I get the picture. You hold still and the copy stays in the slate. Silt's thick. No prowler on this face. The gate paint is on their own truck."

"Then count."

Ren's next breath scrapes. He swallows it. I let him. A lecture on the sound in his chest will not add a second to the gap.

The jack is a recess under the keypad, the size of a thumb, silt gritted into the lip. I blow it clear, seat the tang, and the click runs up my wrist into the bone. The short lead from the slate on my chest clips to the pommel-end. Blue tell. No broadcast. The Spire listens for a voice in the air. This session goes down the door's own wire, into the tap he already owns, and the closed copy sits against my ribs.

"Picture's up," T.J. says. "Doors. Cameras. The pass list. I'm in their security net. Don't pull."

"Talk."

"South stair changes in six minutes. Two on the gate mouth, both facing the truck. This door isn't on their board. The camera over you is pointed at the gantry joint, not the keypad. Hold."

I hold. My free hand stays on the hook at my hip. The slate warms, a small heat over the bone. The picture stays on his console. The weight of the copy sits against my ribs.

"Lab list is in the pull," he says. "Culture lab 4. Active staff. There's a Thorne. Junior synthetics. S..."

"Stop." The rest of the name finishes in my mouth and stays there. The rolls listed her incinerated. I have lived ten years on that line. A desk inside the wall. Junior. A lab that handles living work. The braid against my skull is the same braid she used to wire with stripped copper. "You don't put the rest on this set."

Silt ticks on the keypad. Ren's breath is there, and then it isn't, because he's holding it.

"It's in the slate," T.J. says. "You can pull."

"Pulling."

"Wait." His voice changes. Not the pass. Something he did not ask the door for. "A second message just sat down on the session. The door doesn't use this header."

"Read it."

"Lazarus Key." He says it like a word he is spelling. "Lee over Sector 09 fails in fourteen months. Barrens-air pushed over the Ring. Evacuation

allocation, zero. Dome sealed. There's a line under it with no edge. It won't open."

I have never heard the name. I know the shape of the rest without a briefing. The lee is why the Ring is a city. Barrens-air is the hard hours, the cloth, the nights you do not sleep on the ground floor. Push that over the wall and the stair I came up this morning stops being a place people live.

"Say the first line again."

"Fourteen months. Then the Ring is barrens-air, and nobody on this side of the wall is on a list."

"We came for doors," Ren says.

"I know," T.J. says. "I don't know what this is. It's in the slate with the rest. Tsune, the pass is at the corner. Pull."

I pull the lead, twist the blade back onto the tang, and seat the Bodkin through the braid until the steel sits cold against my skull. The slate stays on the chest strap, face in, tell dark.

The keypad screams.

A klaxon, close enough to put a buzz in the fillings. The jack locks shut.

"Signal left the door," T.J. says. His voice goes thin and fast. "Twenty-five seconds before it has a place. Not on you yet. Move."

"I'll meet you at the stair," Ren says.

"You will not." The gantry runs south under my boots, the wall on my left, a hundred meters of it, smooth, no handhold the eye can love. The south road is a dark cut at the bottom. "Stay on."

I drop to the lower flange, hook the crook, and let the fall stop in the shoulder instead of the spine. Boots hit. The knees take it the way they have since I was seventeen, the landing eaten, the shock thrown back into the metal. I am already moving.

Searchlights rake the main gate. White, then the red off the wall, then white again. The metal under my glove is cold enough to ache. No seam wide enough to hide a person. Below, shutters slam. A whistle cuts the alley. A woman pulls a child by the wrist and neither of them looks up, which is the correct use of a neck.

The header sits in the ear beside the name I would not let him finish. The slate knocks my ribs with both of them, and I do not have a free hand

for either.

"Stay low," T.J. says. "The light is still on the main gate. They're more interested in their own door than in yours. That lasts about as long as the log."

"Then I won't be on the stair."

"Prowler's nose is on the gate road," T.J. says. "It hasn't committed. I have the bearing if it turns."

"Ren, where are you."

"Two roofs off the clinic stair. I can see the lights. Give me the time and I'm there."

The shadow crosses the searchlights.

Fourteen feet of black wing, tucked, falling out of the copper dark above the wall. The sound is feathers cutting air, a whistle with a body in it. Heat comes off the dive before the shape clears the lamp, ozone and hot metal, and every hair on my arm answers it.

"Ren." I have the hook in a reverse grip and the collar tight and the slate against my ribs. "Get to Drew. Kill the set."

"Tsune, don't."

I cut the link.

The channel dies in the ear. The wing keeps coming. I run the gantry south, low, and I do not look up again until the flange turns.

CHAPTER 3

VRAM

> ***The leash.*** *The socket at the back of the neck, and the signal the Spire sends through it. Hesitate, and it hurts. Leave it on for years, and it starts to cook the man.*

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The roost has no rail.

I stand on the lip, boots on frost, three thousand feet of copper dark under the toes. The mast rises through the crown of the dome and stops here, a cap of stone no wider than a street. Wind comes off it hard enough to push a man who is only a man. I am six feet four in the boots, and the lip still feels narrow.

The socket at the back of my neck flares.

It is a round mouth of metal where the head meets the spine, and a short tab under it. The skin around it reddens. The metal stays metal. The signal in it is a thin drill, and tonight the drill is bored. I set my teeth and do not rub it. Rubbing does not make the Spire kinder.

A harvester hangs in the high air, black, silent, no exhaust. We are the things that move. There is no fuel left for a machine that has to come home, so they grew the wing. Flesh knits. Flesh eats paste. A wrecked turbine does not.

The ring under the mast is a bowl of lamps and zinc. Sector 09 burns small. The south gate is a red cluster where a crawler has been sitting too long. I have been watching that cluster since the socket started its hour. The drill and the truck feel like the same impatience.

"Hold still, Commander," Rook says. "You're toasting my flatbread."

Ferrin Calder is on an ammo crate under the windbreak, Hawk wings half open to the stone, a cold round of bread on his glove and a grin he has not earned. He leans the bread toward my shoulder like the heat there is a stove he is allowed to use.

"Put that on my skin and you can retrieve it from the street," I say.

"Promises." He takes a bite of the ration strip instead. "South stacks were filthy yesterday. I stalled. You can write me up, or you can admit the air over Sector 09 is garbage."

"Check your pins before you blame the air."

Cassian does not laugh. He has his arms folded and his own wings tight, a Hawk's, built to stay in a patrol and not to own a drop. Twenty-eight, and the ledge has already made a veteran of his mouth. "North wind is iron. It'll strip a vane if we launch into it for nothing."

"Then we preen after."

"Easy for you." Rook flicks a primary. "A Raven grows the feather back before the cursing is done. Mine whistle for weeks."

Footsteps, softer. Eucalyptus and the sting of salve.

Toby Vance stops a pace off my wing with a foil patch in both hands. Cream vanes, rust along the edge, still twitchy when the mast hums. Cassian's brother. The youngest body on a roost that eats youngest bodies.

"You're squinting," he says. "Left jaw. That's the fourth flare. I traded two tubes for the ice. It helps."

"You need the tubes."

"I ate." He holds the patch out and does not quite meet my eye. "Please, sir."

I take it. The gel is cold against the red skin around the socket, and the drill drops from a scream to a wire. Toby's shoulders drop with it.

"Better," I say.

"Good." He almost smiles, and hates that I saw it.

Amari is on the south corner of the cap, blonde hair cut for the hood, wheat vanes darker on the leading edge. She has been facing the gate, not the joke.

"South face is dirty," she says. "Wind off the crawler well. It will dump you over the road if you take it lazy." She does not soften the next part. "If you wait for a clean lane, whatever they're ringing the siren for will be in the mirrors."

The siren arrives as if she ordered it.

Three wails. The floodlights on the crown snap red. The socket discharges, a snap into the bone, and I go to a knee because the signal does not ask. White for a second. Then the order, plain, in the same place the pain lives.

Breach. South wall. A jack in a service door. Intercept. Retrieve. Open the intruder.

Rook's bread hits the stone. His hand finds the sidearm. Cassian's wings crack once for balance and fold again. Toby's hand is still out, empty.

I stand. The leash wants the next move before I choose it, a hot stitch that means obey. I have killed for less than a stolen file. The stitch does not care whether the body on the gantry is a soldier or a person who found a port.

"South wall," I say. "Cassian, hold the roost until I call the lane. Rook, Toby, lights on the gantry. If she doubles back into the containers, you pin the roofs. You do not drop into the street for a ghost."

"She," Cassian says.

"Light frame. Long stride for the height. Fast, and the tap was clean. The port was seated." The playback is a heat smear on the gantry, already moving south along the wall. "She's making for the mirrors."

"Unregistered?" Rook's grin is gone. "No socket, and still breathing out there?"

"That's why they want her opened." The stitch flares when I linger on it. I roll my neck and the pain sits down, unhappy. "Amari."

"South face," she says. "Dirty all the way to the gate. Don't glide it. Beat, or the wind will put you on the crawler."

"Clear the lip."

Toby steps into the windbreak. Rook lifts two fingers, not quite a salute. Cassian only watches the drop, which is what a second is for. Amari

stays on the corner and gives me the angle with her chin.

I open the wings. Black vanes. The beat puts a blue-violet sheen on the shafts, there and gone. Cold hits the live skin where the feathers leave the back, a slap, then nothing, because the heat eats it. I lean.

The first second is the stomach. The second is the boots with nothing under them. The third belongs to the wings. I have done this since they threw me off a lower ledge as a boy and told a number to fly. The sergeant had no name I was allowed to keep. The air kept me. It is the same air.

The mast falls away. For three breaths there is only the drop, the wall a gray streak, the red lights racing upward past my boots. Then the wings catch and the air hits like a door. They bite. I level over the ring and go down the south face the way Amari named it.

The gate swells. The crawler is a pale block in its own lamps. A heat smear runs the gantry south of it, low, fast, not wasting a stride on a look back. Smart. The mirrors will break a straight dive if I give her the time.

I do not give her the time.

South face. Dirty wind. I beat, the way Amari said, and the road comes up.

CHAPTER 4

THE OFFER

> *Item one: air that stays air. Item two: a roof. Item three: the shooting stops. The price is not on the copy they were given.*

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They breathe the room. I do not.

The table is wood, scarred by other meetings, and the windows behind the ministers still show a street. Carts. A tree that has not yet decided to die. The sky over the tree is the wrong color for their season, a sour brass at the edges, and they have been calling it weather for a month.

I sit inside the sleeve. Glass, a handspan thick, fogged when I speak and clear when I wait. My air stays on my side of it. Theirs stays on theirs. The difference is the whole afternoon, and none of them have asked about my side.

"Item one," I say. The fog blooms and fades. "Air that remains air. Breathable by your children. Stable inside a roof we will raise over the cities you choose."

The minister from the coast leans in. Tired, proud, a stain of lunch on the cuff he thinks we cannot see through glass. "Our surveyors say the brass is a high haze. It breaks on its own."

"It will not." I let that sit. A lie comforts them. A correction makes them feel included. "Item two. The roof. You have been shooting at each other over water and wire. A roof ends the argument about whose street floods. Item three. The shooting stops. We will stand between the armies until they are embarrassed to keep the guns out."

The general, who has not taken his coat off, taps the blank line at the bottom of the page they were given. "And the cost."

"You are already paying the other cost," I say. "Funerals. Failed crops. The brass. We are offering a pause."

"A pause has a price." He is not stupid. I like him more for it, which is not the same as mercy. "Fuel. Land. A base. Say it, so the minutes can record it."

The woman who keeps the minutes looks at me and not at the page. She has the look of a person who survives rooms by writing down what was said and never what was skipped. I smile at her through the glass. The fog hides the teeth and gives them back.

"Write that the first glass goes to the city that signs before the others lose their nerve," I say. "They are about to argue over which of them that is. You will not need me for that part."

They argue. The coast wants the port under glass. The interior wants the grain. The general wants the capital, because a capital that can breathe can keep giving orders. I fold my hands on my side of the table and I let them feel clever. Every city they name is a city that will invite the roof. An invitation is cleaner than a landing.

What I do not say sits in the pause after each of their sentences, and I enjoy the shape of it.

The open country is the thing being spent. The brass at the edge of their sky is not a guest. It is the start of a pressure my own machines will thicken, year by year, while the roofs stay kind. The kindness is real. A child under the glass will breathe. A child outside it will learn a harder hour, and then a harder one, and the boards will call that the weather they failed to fund.

The signature they want me to give them is permission. Not for the air. The air is the sentence they came to hear. Under it, in the authority they will hand over to keep the roofs standing, is the right to raise soldiers out of their orphans and their poor, winged and collared, because a gun that must be fueled is about to become a story. I do not put that sentence on their copy. A spoken price can be refused. A missing sentence gets signed as relief.

"We would need guarantees," the coast minister says. "That your people do not govern the street. That the glass is a shelter, not a flag."

"You will govern the street," I say, and this part is true. "We do not want your courts. We want the work finished."

"What work?"

"The air." I touch the glass from inside. The fog flowers over the fingerprint and dies. "You keep asking for the work as if it were a favor you might decline. Look at the tree."

They look. The leaves are the right shape and the wrong dullness. One of the younger aides has been coughing into a sleeve since I sat down, politely, as if courtesy could bargain with a lung.

"Sign," I say. "Or spend the next year proving the brass is weather. I can wait. Your tree cannot."

The general reads the page again. Three items. A blank where a price would be, which they have filled, in their own mouths, with the honor of being first. He sets his pen down.

"The capital," he says.

"The port," says the coast.

I turn my head inside the sleeve, a small motion, and let them see that I am not impatient. "Put both on the list. The first glass is a race you can win twice if you are willing to share the credit. The minutes can say you were statesmen."

The woman writes. She hesitates over the blank line. Her pen hovers. For a moment I think she will ask what was left out, and the afternoon will become honest, and I will have to give them a smaller gift or none.

She writes *agreed in principle* and does not ask.

"Good," I say.

Outside, a cart rattles. Someone laughs, human and brief. I do not hate them. Hatred is a waste of a long life. They are tired, and they are proud, and they are already dividing a sky they still think is theirs.

I leave the missing sentence where it is. In the fog. In the pause. In the copy they will sign and file and sleep beside.

When the aide coughs again, I do not look at him. The cough is the future, and the future is not an item on their page.

CHAPTER 5

TSUNARI

> *If you answer on an open set, you paint the house you are protecting.*

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The mirrors start where the road gives up.

Black glass, cracked, stood up in rows when somebody still thought the sun could be kept. The wind drives grit through the breaks. It stings the bare skin of my shoulders and packs the corner of my mouth. I pull the goggles down. Under them the membranes wipe once, a clear film, and the grit is gone. I do not blink. I do not slow down.

The earpiece is dead in my ear. I killed it. Ren will be on a roof by now, and Drew will be awake because Ren cannot keep his hands off a door. If I answer, the clinic lights up on somebody's board. T.J.'s hole lights up with it. I leave the set dead and I run.

A shadow crosses the glass ahead of me and is gone. Big. Low. I do not look up long enough to give it a size. The mirrors will break a dive if I stay under them. That is the whole plan.

"Contact," a speaker barks, flattened by the wind. "Runner in the mirror grid. Nets."

Two of them. Ground suits, heavy, the joints hissing as they bound the dunes. Iron Division, or close enough that the difference will not save me. Capture nets. They want the slate and they want the body that carried it still shutting.

I drop into the trench under a tilted bowl. The glass throws their lights into a mess of white. Heat sits in the metal from the day, and their

thermals will hate it. I jam a thumb capacitor into a split servo wire and run a filament across the gap at shin height. One trap. The click of it is a small mechanical thing. The storm stays wind and grit.

The first suit comes around the bowl. Light on his shoulder. A net gun where his hand should be a hand. His shin takes the filament.

The pop is bright and local. His light dies. The suit's knees lock with a hydraulic slam and he goes into the sand on the locked joints, swearing into a speaker that has started to feed back.

"Two, I'm blind. Suit's dead. Two, report."

I am already on the face of the glass. Boot, push, the leg takes the rebound and throws me onto the housing at his shoulder. The pommel of the Bodkin finds the valve behind the helmet and snaps it. Air screams out, cold, a white jet. He claws at the seal. I am off him before he finishes the motion. He will live. He will not chase.

"Two, report," the other one calls. Closer. On the berm, not in the trench. Smarter. "Did you engage?"

His rifle whines up. If he dumps that into the bowls, the glass becomes a cage of bounce. I have the hooks in a reverse grip and four strides of sand.

He crests. "Drop it."

I slide under the line of fire. The shot takes the bowl behind me and the bowl comes apart, a boom, a curtain of black splinters. He covers the visor. I plant, leap, and the second bound puts me at his collar ring. The hook's beak finds the seam under the net gun and tears the feed. The whine dies. I drive a knee into the joint that was hissing and the leg folds. He hits the berm. The net spills, useless, a metal spider with no throw.

I do not stay to tie him. The shadow passes again, lower, a pressure change in the ear, feathers somewhere in the grit. Still no number on it. I put the hooks home and I go deeper into the rows, where the glass is thickest and a straight dive becomes a mistake.

The earpiece knocks my jaw when I land. I do not turn it on.

Drew would already be packing a kit. Ren would already be lying about how close he is. T.J. would give them a bearing and stay in the hole, which

is the only sensible thing any of us does. An answer from me makes all three of those facts into a target.

I wipe the membrane again. The next row of mirrors is a black lane. I take it at a run, on the toes, the way the legs want, and I count the gaps where a wing would have to commit.

Let him commit. I will not be in the gap.

CHAPTER 6

VRAM

> *Recover the runner. The file is worth more than the body.*

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She does not run like prey.

From the dirt lane between the mirrors her heat is wrong. A body in a sprint should burn. Hers stays close to the glass, a cool smear against bowls that are still holding the day. No collar ping. No beacon. The socket in my neck keeps offering me a tag for her and then eating the tag, because there is nothing in her nape for it to bite.

The order sits under that emptiness. Retrieve the packet. Open the intruder. The file is the prize. The body is how the file walks.

I bank once over the rows. The two suits are already down, one venting, one on a berm with a dead net. Clean work. She did not stay to finish them. She went deeper, where a dive has to choose a gap or eat glass.

I choose the gap she left on purpose.

The lane bends. She is already out of it, on the far side of a tilted bowl, and the bowl is where my line wanted to be. She watched the wing. She put the glass in the wing's mouth.

"Clever girl."

It comes out quiet, for me, and the leash does not like the tone. A small stitch, a reminder that admiration is not an order. I tuck. The wings fold. The gap rushes up, grit and black splinters, and I go through it on the angle she did not quite close.

She hears the feathers and she turns with a hook already in her hand. Fast. Low. The center of her is under the strike, not above it. I hit her anyway, because mass and a dive still count, and we go through the rotted door of a mirror shack in a smash of wood and dust.

The floor takes us. Glass. Wire. Her breath leaves in one hard sound and comes back armed. I get a forearm across the hook before the beak finds the socket. The socket is screaming from the impact, skin hot, metal indifferent. I do not give her the nape.

"Packet," I say. "On the ground. Hands where I can see them."

She laughs once, no humor in it, and tries to put a knee where a knee ends a fight. I turn the hip. The shin guard takes the second hook. We are chest to chest in the wreck of the shack, her collar against my throat, the slate a hard corner between us.

Cool. That is the fact my skin reports and does not file. The desert is a furnace. She is not.

"You talk like the file is yours," she says. "It was in a pipe."

"It's mine now."

"Then take it." Her eyes are amber behind the grit on the goggles, the pupils cut to slits. "If you can find a hand free."

I cannot. That is the problem. The order wants her opened. My hands are busy keeping the hooks out of my neck, and some stupid part of the dive is still pleased she made me work for the gap.

The leash stitches again. Obey.

I drive us over, get the high ground of a knee, and reach for the strap of the slate. She bites. Not a metaphor. Teeth at the wrist, and then she is gone under me by a twist that should not have been there, boots on the floor, already measuring the door.

I catch the collar. Fabric. The throat under it is bare of metal. I feel that and I hate that I felt it.

"Run," I say, "and the next pass breaks the glass with you in it."

She looks at the door, at my hand, at the wing jammed crooked against the shack wall. She stays. For a heartbeat. Then the hook comes up again, and we are not done.

CHAPTER 7

TSUNARI

> *They took our children with promises of wings. They gave them iron in their necks and sent them back to shoot us for breathing.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The second time he takes me down, the floor is the one that loses.

We hit brick. Dust in the mouth. A wing slams the wall and the shack complains, a long wooden sound, and then his weight is the whole room. Heat comes off him in a sheet. Ozone. Hot metal. The smell sits in the feathers crushed against my cheek, and my body answers it before I give it permission, a jolt low in the stomach that I file under *insult* and keep moving.

Bodkin is still in the bun. The hooks are in my hands until they are not. He checks one with the shin guard, a hard ugly block, and the beak skids off. The other he takes at the wrist. Fingers like a clamp. He finds the second wrist on the way down and pins both of them over my head in one grip, because he is willing to spend a wing as a brace and I am not willing to let the Bodkin stay a hairpin.

I twist. The braid scrapes brick. If I can get the twist of the bun against his forearm, the blade unseats. Two inches. He reads it and shifts the grip higher, onto the meat of the wrists, away from the hair.

"Stop," he says.

"You first."

His jaw is scarred on the left, a pale hook of old burn, and the mouth under it is close enough that I can see the grit on his lip. I look at the door instead. The door is an exit if his knee slips. The hip under the knee is the

lever. The knife is the finish if the wrists come free. I count those three things and I do not count his mouth again.

He is burning. The chest against mine is a furnace through the plate, and the bare arms are worse, skin too hot for a man who just came out of a night dive. I know what a Raptor does with heat. I pull it. I do not fix it. Whatever is wrong with him is not a fever I was taught to cure, and my skin is doing the only trick it has, taking the temperature down a degree at the places we touch and giving me nothing useful back.

"The slate," he says. "Then you walk out of this shack."

"You were told to open me."

His eyes change. He did not expect me to have the order. Good. An order he is ashamed of is a crack.

"I was told to recover a runner," he says. "The file is the point."

"Then you can have the file when my hands are my hands."

He leans in to stop a buck of the hips and the heat spikes. The feathers at his shoulder brush my throat above the collar. I hate him with a clean, useful hate. He is the thing they made out of a child and sent back to shoot the street for breathing. He is also, right now, a man who has not broken my wrists when he could have, and that fact is more dangerous than the knee.

I test the grip. Solid. I test the hip. If I drop my weight and turn into the pinned arm, the knee has to choose between my ribs and the floor. I start the drop.

He feels it. Of course he feels it. The wing braces harder. Brick dust ticks down onto both of us.

"Don't," he says, and it is not the leash talking. The leash would have told him to finish the order. This is him, close, furious, trying to keep a fight from becoming a killing.

I look at the scar so I do not look at the mouth.

"Get off me," I say, "or I find out what your neck does when a knife goes looking for it."

His grip tightens. He does not reach for the bun. I do not get the Bodkin free. We stay there, heat and brick and the slate digging into my ribs, and the fight is not over. It has only run out of easy blood.

CHAPTER 8

VRAM

> *If the noise in your skull stops, you report it. A quiet soldier is a broken soldier.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Her hand gets free because I want the Bodkin more than I want both wrists.

I reach for the bun. She turns into the reach. The freed hand slaps past my jaw, misses the eye, and lands on the open back of the collar, fingers spread, hunting a grip in a fight and finding the socket instead.

The tab is short. The iris is a mouth. Her palm covers both.

The mesh stops.

Ten years of it, the drill in the hour, the stitch when I admire a target, the order sitting in the teeth, all of it goes out like a lamp. What is left is the shack. Brick. Her breath. My own pulse, which I can hear, which I have not heard without a second voice under it since they seated the metal.

I hit my knees.

The wing drags. The grip I still have on her other wrist locks, and the knuckles go white around it, and that is the only strength I trust. If I let go she runs, and if she runs the hand leaves, and if the hand leaves the noise comes back. I know this the way a man knows a burn. I do not know why.

She is as frightened as I am.

I see it in the way she stares at her own hand, as if the hand has done a thing she did not order. Cool skin. That part I already had. The desert on her, the grit, the low heat of a body that does not waste itself. This is not that. The cool is sitting in my arms where we touched and it has not

touched the noise. The noise is simply gone, and her face says she did not bring a name for the gone.

"What did you," she starts, and stops. Her mouth works. A sentence gets as far as the teeth and dies there. "If it cannot..."

She does not finish it. I do not ask. Asking would be a report, and a report needs the channel, and the channel is a noise I am not ready to invite back.

Wild sage, faint, under the sweat at her throat. I should not be close enough to have it. I am. My knees are in the dust on either side of her hips. The waist under my forearm is muscle and a held breath, and the body, the stupid loyal animal of it, answers before the soldier does. Heat of a different kind. A pull. I am hard against the inside of my own thigh and the shame of it is immediate and total.

She is an insurgent with a stolen file and blood on the idea of her boots. She is not a woman in a room I chose. The body does not take the correction.

"Don't move," I say. It comes out rough. "Hand stays."

"I'm not doing anything." Her voice shakes and she hates that it shakes. I can hear the hate. It helps. "I grabbed you. That's the whole trick. Let go of my wrist and I'll take the hand back."

"No."

The leash should punish that. *No* to a retrieval, *no* to an open intruder, *no* to a quiet soldier who does not call the quiet in. Nothing punishes it. The socket under her palm is warm metal and quiet meat. The skin around it, which has been angry for a decade, is only skin.

I am terrified of her. I am terrified of the minute she understands what she is holding. An uncollared woman in a mirror shack just shut the Spire out of my head, and if she tells anyone, I am a broken asset, and if she does not tell anyone, I am something worse. I am a man who felt the silence and will not give it up.

Her free wrist turns in my fist. Testing. Still measuring. Even now.

"You're burning up," she says. "That part I know. The rest of this..." She looks at the hand on my neck as if it might bite her. "I don't know the rest of this."

"Then we are the same."

I hate that I said it. The arousal is still there, humiliating, a pulse I cannot order down, and her eyes flick once to the place where my body has betrayed the pin. She files it. Of course she files it. Leverage, even here.

"Report it," she says, very soft, and she is quoting something she does not have, or guessing the rule from my face. "A quiet soldier is a broken soldier. Isn't that the line?"

"Yes."

"Are you going to?"

The channel is in my jaw. A word would bring the roost. Cassian. The siren. The noise.

I keep her wrist. I keep her hand where it is. I do not call.

"No," I say.

Outside, the grit ticks on the shack. Inside, for the first time in ten years, the only sound in my skull is us.

CHAPTER 9

JEFFREY

> *Write down the cough. Write down nothing else.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The raid is already in the street. I can hear the boots on the grate above the workshop, not hurried, which is worse. Hurried men miss a door. These ones are counting.

Tsunari sits on the stool with her sleeve over her mouth. Seventeen. The haze has been in her breath for a month, a dry rattle that the city is still calling dust. It is not dust. I have written the cough down. I have written nothing else, because anything else on a page can be taken, and a page does not love her.

Five dishes on the bench. I count them the way I count exits. One. Two. Three. Four. Five. Glass, and a film on each that catches the lamp and gives it back wrong. I name the one I can afford to name.

"The culture," I tell her. "It stops the cough. That is the mercy. Say it back."

"The culture stops the cough." Her voice is thin and furious, which means she is still herself. "What are the other four?"

"You counted them."

"You made me count them."

"And I am not going to name them." I cap the one I named. My hands are steady. My reasons are not. "A dish can be carried out of this room in a coat. A note can be read by a man who was not in the room. The cough will not wait for a stranger who volunteers. You are here. You are dying on a schedule the street has not admitted. I am using you. I need you to hear

that before the needle, so you do not spend the rest of your life calling it a gift you misunderstood."

She looks at the inner door. Sora is behind it, ten, asleep, a lump under a blanket I checked an hour ago and will not check again. If I open that door I will do the coward's arithmetic and put this in the child who is not sick, because a healthy body is a cleaner page. I do not open it.

"She's not part of this," I say.

"I know." Tsunari pulls the sleeve down. The rattle is there, small, indecent in a room this quiet. "Do it before I decide to be brave and stupid."

I do it. The culture first, because that is the sentence I can live with. The rest goes in after, unnamed, into the daughter who is already failing, because a body that does not know its own name is harder to steal than a slide. I hate the arithmetic while my hands keep it. Hate does not stop the work. If I stop, the dishes leave with the boots, and she keeps the cough, and Sora wakes up to neither of us.

When it is in her I make her stand. The legs will be stronger than she expects. The skin will run cool. Scales will come in on the shoulders and the arms, slate, and she will hide them. A clear film will wipe her eyes. She will click in a dark room and know where the walls are. She will pull heat off a warmer body and she will not fix that body. I tell her all of that in the plain words, the Raptor, because she has to live in it and she has to hide the nape. Her blood does not go on a company slide. Ever.

"If it cannot go home," I say, "it cooks. Again."

"If it cannot go home, it cooks." She frowns. "That's a bad culture."

"Say it until it is cold."

She says it again. She does not understand it. Good. Understanding is a thing an interrogator can pull. A sentence she can repeat without knowing why is only a habit.

"Mercer finishes this," I say. "The clinic. The knife. The trade. He does not get the notes. There are no notes."

"Where are you going?"

"Out. In the crawler. They will follow the crawler if I make the crawler the louder fact." I take her face in my hands, brief, and let go, because a

long touch becomes a goodbye and a goodbye becomes a speech. "If this fails, I cut you open for a blank. I am afraid of that. If it holds, the people on the stair will not kill you. They will keep you. I am more afraid of that. Do not be interesting. Do not be brave where a collar can see you."

Boots on the stair now. I kill the lamp over the bench. Four dishes stay where a fire will find them. The fifth is already in her, and so is the thing I will not say.

I go up the other stair, the one that comes out in the alley, and I make sure the crawler's lamps are on and the engine is a rude, trackable noise. Shouts behind me. A light swings off the workshop door and onto the lane.

They follow.

I do not look back at the alley mouth. The crawler takes the south road, loud on purpose, and the strike team comes with it, away from the stool, away from the inner door, away from the girl who is about to learn a new way to be cold.

The road does not get a name from me. Not tonight. Tonight the job is the noise, and the noise is working.

CHAPTER 10

TSUNARI

> *Record closed. Boy, seven years old. Fast hands, good eyes. Family unknown. Taken for the draft. No belongings returned.*

❖ ❖ ❖

I wake with my wrists in a mag-cuff and the prowler already moving.

The bench across from me holds the raven. Harness smoking faintly at the wing roots, eyes too bright, a tremor in the hand that is not on the tiller because he is not driving yet. Someone else is, up front, a silhouette and a closed hatch. He put me in the back and sat where he could see the door and my hands.

The quiet is gone.

I know it the way you know a room after the fan cuts out. In the shack his skull had been a held breath. Here the breath is back, and it is hurting him. The tremor starts in the fingers and climbs the forearm. He breathes like a man counting, and the count is losing.

My hand is free enough, if I lean. The cuff is on the wrists together, not on the wall. A mistake, or a bargain he made with himself. I lean. I put two fingers on the inside of his wrist, skin to skin, the way you check a pulse when you want the other person to think that is all you are doing.

The tremor stops.

His eyes shut. One second. Two. The smoking at the harness thins. When he looks at me again he is ashamed of the relief, which tells me the relief is real.

I take the fingers away.

The tremor returns, meaner, as if the absence charged it. He makes a sound he does not mean to make. I put the fingers back. It stops. I have no name for the stopping. The cool of my skin is a trick I was taught, and it is not this. This is a switch. On when I touch. Off when I don't.

"You need the hand," I say.

"I need the packet." His voice is wrecked. "The hand is a malfunction."

"Call it that on your report." I keep the fingers where they are, light, easy to remove. "You didn't call the shack in. I was awake for that part. So we can sit here and pretend you're in charge, or you can tell me where this prowler is going before the man up front asks why your prisoner is taking your pulse."

He looks at the hatch. He looks at the cuff. He does not look at the place where my fingers meet his wrist, which is how I know he is thinking about it.

"South," he says. "Away from the gate. The beacon will want the Spire. I am not giving it the Spire."

"Because they'll open me."

"Because they'll open both of us, if anyone repeats what your hand just did."

Useful. He is afraid of the same minute I am. A man who needs a touch he cannot explain will bargain. A man who is ashamed of the bargain will lie to his own side before he lies to me. I can work with that. I cannot work with a corpse, and if I take the hand away for long enough I think I get one.

"Then the hand stays," I say. "Until we're out of this box. You don't ask what I am. I don't ask what they wrote down when they took you. We both already hate the answers."

The record in my head is not his. I don't have his file. I have a boy-shaped hole the city leaves in people, and his face is the age that hole grows up to be. Fast hands. I watched them trap a hook. I will not do him the violence of reciting a life I was not given.

"Deal," he says, and the word costs him.

The prowler hits a rut. My fingers slip. The tremor flashes, ugly, and I put the hand back flatter, palm this time, and I watch him hate how fast he leans into it.

Good. Hate is a lever. Need is a better one. I keep my palm on his wrist and I start counting the turns, south, south, and the graveyard falling behind us in the dark.

CHAPTER 11

VRAM

> ***Redoubt Station 14.*** *A concrete watchpost on the south edge of the ring. Shortwave only. The city cannot hear what happens inside.*

❖ ❖ ❖

I take the driver's seat when the road clears the graveyard.

The man who had the tiller is a courier with a route and a beacon that wants to go home. I pull his beacon, kill it, and point the prowler at a post the city does not listen to. He argues once. I show him the hatch. He takes the hint and the long walk back toward the lamps. I do not watch him go. If he reports, he reports a commander who relieved him. Commanders relieve people. They do not steal prisoners. Not yet. The lie can wait until someone asks a question I cannot file.

She is in the cabin because the back bench put her hand at the wrong angle and the tremor came up at every rut. Her palm is on my forearm now, under the line of the window, where a scope on a ridge would need luck. The quiet holds. I drive.

The lee thins as the road drops south. The air in the ring was breathable and dirty. Out here it is thinner in the lungs, a scratch, the first taste of the country the dome decided not to keep. I don't explain it to her. She has lived in it. The word is the lee. Past the lee is the Choke, and we are not going that far. Seven miles from the mast, the concrete box on the south edge, shortwave only. Redoubt Station 14. If I take her into the city they open her on a table and they open me for not calling the shack. The post is a delay. I am good at calling a delay an order.

I look at her once.

The tunic leaves the shoulders bare. Slate scales on the outer shoulder, small, pebbled, catching the cabin lamp and giving it back dull. She sees me see them. Her mouth parts, not a smile, a refusal, and my pulse kicks for a reason that has nothing to do with the road.

My hands tighten on the wheel.

If I reach for her she will use the Bodkin I have not found yet, or her teeth, or the simple fact that I need the palm on my arm more than she needs me alive. I would deserve it. I keep the hands on the wheel. I keep my eyes on the ruts.

"You're staring," she says.

"Once."

"Make it the only once."

"The scales."

"Are none of your report." She shifts the palm, a warning and a mercy in the same inch. The quiet wobbles and settles. "Where are we going."

"A watchpost. Concrete. No line to the Spire. If I do this right, the city thinks the runner is still in the mirrors."

"And if you do it wrong?"

"Then I drove you to a box with one door and I am the man in the box with you." I hear how that sounds. "You can hate that after we're inside. Hating it on the road gets us both a retrieval."

The post comes up as a low wall and a mast too short to be proud. I kill the prowler's lamps before the last rise. The lee scratches at the window seal. Her hand stays. I let it stay until the wheels stop, and then I make myself move first, because a commander who cannot leave a touch is a commander already retired.

The fever starts its climb the moment her skin leaves mine. I get the door open anyway.

"Inside," I say. "Walk. I'm not carrying you where a scope can write it down."

CHAPTER 12

TSUNARI

> ***Shortwave.*** *A voice that can cross a few miles of bad air and cannot reach the dome. Anyone with a set can hear it.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The post is a concrete room with one door, a stove that has not been lit, and a shortwave set on a crate. No line to the city. I know that because the set is the old kind, a whip antenna on the roof and a dial that will not reach a dome switchboard if you beg it. Anyone with another set can hear us. The Spire cannot. He chose that. I file it.

I count the exits while he locks the prowler out. Door. A slit window, too narrow for my shoulders, wide enough for a voice. A roof hatch with the bolts on this side, which is a gift if I get a minute without his hands. The stove poker. A coil of wire. The cuffs are off. He took them off in the cabin so I could walk, and because his tremor had started to show in the jaw.

He turns his back to hang the harness. Bronze skin, the wing roots angry and red where the straps sat. I look at the hatch bolts instead. A back is not an exit.

The shortwave clicks.

I know the click. T.J. builds his sets mean and quiet, and this one is not his, but the squelch is the same weather. Then Drew.

"Tsune. If you're on this road, answer. Ren is with me. We're at the last mirror. T.J. gave us the bearing and he is staying down, so don't ask me to make him brave."

Ren, smaller, too close to her mic: "We're not going back until we see the prowler."

Vram's head comes around. He heard the name. Drew. He does not move for the set, which is either discipline or the tremor eating his timing. I cross the room before he chooses. I thumb the send.

"Turn around."

"Tsune." Drew's relief is a crack in the word. "Are you hurt?"

"Turn around. Both of you. The bearing was a direction, not an invitation. Go home. Tell T.J. the watch is done and he keeps the hole."

"There's someone in the room," she says. Not a question. Drew hears a second breath the way other people hear a siren.

"Yes. You don't get a name. You don't get a place. If you keep walking south you paint every door you slept near. Go home."

Ren starts, "We can..."

"Ren." I put the field voice on, the one that makes him stand up straight. "You get to Drew's cart and you face the gate. If I hear this set again tonight I will assume you want a patrol to learn your names. Confirm."

A pause. The lee scratches the slit window. Vram is three steps away, shaking, listening, taking nothing I am not spending.

"Confirm," Drew says. "We're turning around. Mercer will ask."

"Tell him you lost the signal at the mirrors." I pull the relay. The set dies under my hand. The room is concrete and breath again.

Vram looks at the dead dial, then at me.

"Drew," he says.

"Is a person you don't have." My palm is not on him. The tremor is in his shoulders now, fine and constant. I see him decide not to ask for the hand. Pride, or the last of the order. "You heard a name. You did not hear a clinic. You did not hear a hole. If you repeat the name on any channel, the next thing I touch will not be your wrist."

He nods once. It costs him. The fever is climbing and he is still standing in it, which is either impressive or the thing that gets us both killed by morning.

"Shortwave only," he says. "You just proved you understand the post."

"I understand you drove me somewhere the city can't hear." I sit on the crate, between him and the set, and I put my hand on the wood. Not on him. Let him ask. "When you need it, you say so. I'm not your medicine. I'm the woman who can take the noise away, and I have just sent my people home so you don't get them. Remember which part you earned."

He looks at the floor. The harness drips heat into the concrete. Outside, the road back to the mirrors stays empty, and I hang the whole night on Drew doing what she said.

CHAPTER 13

DREW

> **A *bearing.*** *A direction from a boy who will not leave his bunker. It can tell you which road. It cannot tell you to come up.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The clinic door sticks. I shoulder it, kit on one hip, shortwave on the other, and the lane is already full of grit. Afternoon. The lee tastes like the stove when Mercer burns the cheap oil. I pull a cloth up over my mouth and I don't make a speech about it.

T.J. is in my ear before I'm ten steps gone.

"South. The prowler turned south off the gantry. I'm not coming up."

"I wasn't going to ask you."

"You were." He is fourteen and he is right, which is the worst age for being right. "Ren already left. He took the left-hand cart. If you don't catch him he'll try the gate road and get himself a light in the face."

"Stay on the bearing. Stay in the hole. If the bearing changes you say so. You do not get noble."

"I don't leave the desk." A click of his tongue, solder-shop impatience. "Cloth on. The silt's still falling. Drew. Bring her back."

"That's the job."

I find Ren at the third turning, too tall for the cart and too young for the set he's hugging. He starts to explain. I point at the seat. He sits. We take the south road because a boy who will not leave a bunker still knows which way a prowler went, and a direction is the only map I'm getting.

The mirrors come up black and broken. I hate them. Too many places to put a body. I keep the lamp low. Ren wants to call her name. I put a hand

on the set.

"Open channel," I say. "You paint the clinic if you get chatty. You paint him, too, and he is fourteen and under a street."

"I know what she is," Ren says, small. "I'm not going to say it."

"Good. Don't practice."

I know the bare nape. I have had that throat under a shop lamp, fitting a lead, telling her to hold still. Scales on the shoulder, skin where a socket should be, nothing to report and nothing I will ever put on a slide. The tang for her Bodkin is in my belt now, wrapped, because I work the tools when the woman is not in the shop. It gives my hands a job. The job is not a confession.

The post shows itself as a squat concrete block past the last mirror, one mast, no city lights. I can see it. I cannot walk up to it. A watchpost has a door and a gun and a reason. I stop the cart where the road dips.

"Tsune. If you're on this road, answer. Ren is with me. We're at the last mirror. T.J. gave us the bearing and he is staying down, so don't ask me to make him brave."

Ren leans in. "We're not going back until we see the prowler."

The answer comes quick, her voice, the field one.

"Turn around."

Relief hits so hard I have to put a hand on the cart. "Tsune. Are you hurt?"

"Turn around. Both of you. The bearing was a direction, not an invitation. Go home. Tell T.J. the watch is done and he keeps the hole."

There is a second breath in the room. Not hers. Close to the set, trying not to be. A man, I think. I don't get a face. I don't get a name. I hate the not-knowing with a clean shop hate, the kind that wants a bolt to turn.

"There's someone in the room," I say.

"Yes. You don't get a name. You don't get a place. If you keep walking south you paint every door you slept near. Go home."

Ren starts. She cuts him with his name, and she tells me what to tell Mercer, and then the set goes dead under her hand. I hear the death of it. I sit with it for three breaths because if I turn the cart in the first breath I will turn it back.

"We're going," I say.

"She might be saying that because he's making her."

"She might." I get the cart around. The mile back is longer than the mile out. "She asked. We go. You can hate me at the clinic."

T.J. takes the news without a hero speech. "Watch is done. I'm down." The channel clicks off. Ren doesn't talk. The mirrors slide past. I put the cloth up again when the grit thickens, and I count the tools in the kit so I don't count the ways a concrete room can go wrong.

Mercer is at the stove when we come in. He looks at the empty half of the doorway.

"Well?"

"Lost the signal at the mirrors," I say.

It is the sentence she gave me. It is not the post, and it is not the second breath, and it is not the throat I have seen and will not describe. He nods like a man who has accepted worse lies from better reasons. I hang the kit. I set the wrapped tang on the bench where her hands will look for it, if she comes back to look.

Then I wash the grit off the burn on my left hand, and I don't tell the room how far we actually got.

CHAPTER 14

VRAM

> *The moment a commander values one life over the order, retire him. Retire the wing with him.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The monitor on the crate is a field unit, stupid and honest. I stand six feet from her and it climbs. One hundred and six. Seven. Eight. The tremor comes back into the hands. The leash finds the quiet I have been hiding and starts to punish the hiding, a hot wire behind the eyes.

"Touch," I say.

She looks at the number. She looks at me. She puts her palm on my wrist, the same bargain as the prowler, and the number falls. Not to a man's. To a thing I can stand in. The wire goes quiet. I hate the monitor for telling the truth and I hate her for being the only switch, and I leave my wrist under her hand because the alternative is on the screen.

"You measured it," she says.

"So I would stop pretending it was the road."

The set on the desk lights. Not the shortwave. The command channel, the one a post is not supposed to need and always has, a tight beam, encrypted, her voice already tired of the distance.

Director Elena Corvus.

"Commander. The runner. Status."

Tsunari's hand stays. I cover the mic with a look and she understands. She does not breathe loud.

"The packet is not in the mirrors," I say. True. The packet is in this room, under a harness I have not opened, because opening it is the next

order and the next order ends her.

"I did not ask about the packet. I asked about the runner. If you cannot show me a body that can be opened, you execute and you confirm. A live thief with a Spire record is a conversation I will not be having on a south-road beam."

Execute.

The word is clean. I have obeyed cleaner words. The doctrine sits underneath it, the one they make you say until it is furniture: the moment a commander values one life over the order, retire him, retire the wing with him. Cassian is on that wing. Toby. Rook. Amari on the south corner with her dirty wind. My life is not the one in the sentence. Hers is. The order wants hers ended so the file can be discussed without a mouth attached.

Six feet away, without her hand, I am already at a hundred and eight and climbing. With her hand I can think. Thinking is the problem. A broken soldier reports the quiet. I did not report it. A loyal commander executes. I am still standing here with her pulse against my wrist, slate scales dull in the crate-lamp, mouth shut, eyes on me like she is counting whether I am about to become the gun.

"Commander."

"The runner is dead," I say.

The first lie of my life. It comes out level. Training is good for that. Training does not care what you spend it on.

"Say it so the log can keep it."

"Lost in the sand. The storm took the body. No recovery. I am holding Redoubt Station 14 until the weather clears. The south road is closed."

A pause. Corvus does not waste warmth. "Weather."

"Yes, Director."

"Hold the post. Send the packet when the beam is clean. If I learn you kept a live one for a reason of your own, I will retire the wing to make the lesson short."

"Understood."

The channel drops. The room is the monitor's small tick and her hand and the lie, sitting between us like a third person with my voice.

She takes her palm away. The number starts to climb. She watches it. She puts the palm back before it reaches the bad place, and the mercy of that is worse than the order, because mercy means she heard me spend the wing and she has not decided what to charge me for it.

"You lied," she says.

"Yes."

"They'll kill them if she checks."

"If she checks, yes."

"Then don't give her a reason to walk down here." Her fingers settle, not kind, exact. "And don't tell yourself you did it for me. You did it because the noise stops when I touch you, and you wanted the noise to stay stopped. I can use that. I won't thank you for it."

I nod. The doctrine I was taught is still in the room. I have valued one life over the order. The life is hers. The wing is still out there, trusting a weather report.

I do not call them.

I sit down on the crate so the six feet become two, and I let the monitor show a number I can live with, and I do not take my wrist out from under her hand.

CHAPTER 15

CASSIAN

> *Runner lost in the sand. No body. The commander is holding the south post until the weather clears.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Corvus does not sit. The roost office is a glass box under the mast, and she stands at the window as if the south road might apologize.

"Again," she says.

I give her the clean version, because a clean version is what a wingman is for.

"Runner lost in the sand. No body. The commander is holding the south post until the weather clears. Redoubt Station 14. He relieved the courier. The beacon was killed so the storm wouldn't paint the prowler for every scavenger on the ring."

I hear myself doing it. The sentences are smooth. They have the shape of a report I would trust if another Hawk had brought it to me. Vram's voice on the beam had been level. Vram's voice is level when he is about to drop and level when he is hurt. I have known him long enough to hate that I cannot tell those apart from a log.

"Weather," Corvus says, the same way she says a name she intends to fire.

"The south face was dirty on launch. Specialist Swift called it. If he waited for a clean lane he would have been late."

"I did not ask for the specialist's weather. I asked for a body." She turns. The office lamp puts a hard line on her mouth. "A thief took a Spire packet and your commander has a storm instead of a corpse. You will confirm

the report to the wing. You will not decorate it. If the weather clears and he is still sitting on an empty post, you bring him up, or I retire the wing to save myself the minutes."

"Yes, Director."

I do not tell her the socket burned on the ledge before the siren. I do not tell her I have been afraid of that metal since the day they seated mine. Fear of the siphon is not a report. Loyalty is. Vram is burning through a hunt that went strange. He is sitting on a post because the lattice is loud and he does not trust a city desk with a corpse he cannot show. That is the story I can stand in. I file the rest under weather. I do not desert. I have a brother on this wing, and a joke-teller, and a specialist who watches the dirty lanes, and a commander who has never asked me to lie.

I do not know that he has.

Amari is on the south corner of the ledge when I come up, hood off, blonde hair cut for it, wheat vanes tucked. The wind up here is the same iron as launch.

"Well?" she says.

"Holding the post. Runner lost in the sand. No body."

She looks south, not at me. "The south wind didn't read like a death."

It is a doubt. She does not hand me a secret to keep. She hands me a feeling, and feelings are how people get a wing retired. I nod as if she had said the visibility was poor.

"File it as weather," I say. "Same as him."

Rook is in the mess hatch with a tin cup, already performing for an audience of Toby. "So he's camping. Good. If the commander is waiting on weather, the weather can pay for supper. I'll put it on the Directorate's slate."

Toby almost smiles. The mess, which had gone quiet when I walked in, remembers how to talk. That is Rook's actual job, whatever the roster says. He keeps a room from hearing itself think.

Toby falls in beside me on the way to the rail. Cream and rust at the edge of the folded wing. Younger than me by enough years that I still check his harness without being asked.

"His neck," Toby says. "Before launch. Was it bad?"

"The usual burn."

"He rubbed it."

"He always looks like he's about to rub it. He doesn't." I put a hand on the rail. The south is a brown smear and a few red lamps where the gate still thinks it matters. "Usual burn, Toby. We hold until he calls the road clear."

"And if he doesn't call?"

"Then I go get him." I make it sound like a plan and not like a fear. "You're not in that flight unless I say. Tell Rook his supper joke can wait until there's something to eat."

Toby goes. Amari stays on the corner, watching a wind she does not trust. I watch the log in my head, the clean sentences, the way they felt true in my mouth.

A quiet soldier is a broken soldier. Vram did not report a quiet. He reported a death and a weather hold. I believe him. I have to. The wing is a thing that falls apart the hour we start checking our commander's weather against the sky.

I leave the doubt on the ledge with Amari, and I go to tell the roost what I was told.

THE GLASS MOTH

The shack leans. Downwind of the ring, where the lee runs thin, the roofs are zinc and the zinc ticks when the grit comes. Miri is nine. She has a fuse tube in her pocket and a tin cup she is not supposed to waste.

Her grandmother coughs in the cot. The cough is small and dry, a rattle that has been in the shack longer than the cup. Miri waits it out. Then she takes the cup and the tube and she goes to the drip at the north eave, where last night's wet still beads on a blackened pipe.

The moth is on the pipe.

Wings clear as a scrap of glass, veins a thin green, no bigger than her thumbnail. One leg is stuck in a tarry drip. The wings shiver and do not lift. Miri crouches the way she crouches for anything that can be broken by a hand in a hurry. She breathes through her mouth. The air scratches. She does not make a lesson of it. She works the leg free with a fingernail, slow, and the moth steps onto her knuckle as if the knuckle had been the plan.

"There," she says.

She eases it into the fuse tube. Cork at one end, already cut. Cork at the other, gentle, with a pin-hole because she has done this wrong once and does not want a second still body in a glass. The moth opens its wings inside the tube. For a moment the shack's bad light becomes a small clean light, green at the edges.

Miri grins. The grin is the whole point. She holds the tube up and turns it, and the wings throw a speck of color on her wrist, and she laughs once, quiet, so the cough in the cot does not have to compete.

Inside, her grandmother is awake, eyes wet from the fit, hand out for the cup.

"Dew," Miri says. "Half for you."

She pours a thimble's worth. It is not much. It is cold. Her grandmother drinks it and makes a face that means the water is real, and then she sees the tube.

"You caught a lamp."

"A moth." Miri sits on the edge of the cot and holds the glass where the old eyes can find it. "It was stuck. It isn't now."

They watch the wings open and shut. The rattle stays in the room. The grit ticks on the zinc. Miri keeps her shoulder against her grandmother's arm, and the moth keeps its small green light, and for as long as the dew lasts in the cup neither of them owes the road an explanation.

CHAPTER 16

TSUNARI

> ***A wing root.*** *The place the wing grows out of the back. The socket sits above it. What she is about to see is bone, metal, and a body that was built, not born that way.*

❖ ❖ ❖

He hangs the harness on the crate and the wing comes with it, heavy, wrong in a concrete room.

The post is the same box. Shortwave dead on the dial I killed. My slate is face-in on the strap. He has not asked for the hand in an hour, and the tremor is back in the jaw because of it. He peels the shirt anyway. The straps have cut red grooves where the wing leaves the back. Above that, the socket: one round mouth of metal, a short tab, the skin on both sides swollen and angry, as if the body has been trying to close over a thing that will not close.

Black quills come out of the live bone. Not a costume. A growth. I look once. The light from the crate lamp moves over the scarred muscle and the place the feathers seat, and my stomach answers before I give it a job. Heat, low, indecent. I put my eyes on the bolt of the roof hatch.

"You can hate it from there," he says. His voice is rough. "I have to clean it or the next beat tears."

"I'm not your nurse."

"I didn't ask for one." He works a cloth along the root, careful, the way a man cleans a weapon he did not choose. The wing shifts. Feathers tick the wall. "The socket cooks if I leave the sweat in it. The wing cooks if I

leave the grit. They built both to be used. They did not build either to be kept."

I hear the lie he told Corvus sitting under that. A weather hold. A dead runner. His hands are steady on the cloth and shaking everywhere else.

"Turn," I say.

He turns. The chest is a furnace even across the room. Bronze skin, old burns, a scar at the jaw I already know. Beautiful is the word I refuse. Built is the word that fits. Somebody took a boy and grew a weapon out of his back, and the weapon is eating the man who has to carry it.

I cross the concrete because the tremor has climbed into his shoulder and the cloth has stopped moving. Two fingers on the inside of his wrist. The shake dies. His eyes shut.

"That's the bargain," I say. "You don't get a sermon with it. And you don't get to call this mercy."

"I won't." He opens his eyes. The want in them is plain and he hates it as much as I hate the heat in my own stomach. "Stay until the root is clean. Then take the hand back. I can stand the noise better when I know the time."

I stay. I watch the hatch, not the mouth. The quills under my free hand are hot and alive, and I file the fact where I file leverage: a body that was made, still choosing, for this hour, not to spend me.

CHAPTER 17

VRAM

> *You had a name. You will answer to the number.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Dusk takes the south face and turns it violet, then brass. I stand on the watchpost step because the room is too small for the wing and for her both.

She leans on the low wall. Profile, goggles up, the collar still doing its job. The lee scratches. She pulls her cloth higher and the cold still finds the bare shoulder. I feel it from here, the way I feel a change in the wind. She hurts in weather that only annoys me. Storm-born, both of us, and the graft spent the difference on my side.

"You keep a distance," she says, without looking.

"The distance is the post."

"The distance is you."

The memory comes up without my leave. A dormitory ward in the Ring, Sector 09, rows of cots and a number painted on the beam. I had a name. They took the blanket, then the name. A sergeant with no name I was allowed to keep pointed at the floor and said the sentence they make you repeat until it replaces the other one. You had a name. You will answer to the number. Subject AE-701. I was seven. The transport smelled like hot metal and fear that was mine.

I do not give her the number. A number is a handle.

"They drafted out of the Ring," I say. "Orphan wards. Fast hands. They told us the wing was a gift."

"And you believed them."

"I was seven." The railing under my hand goes tight. The knuckles pale once, and I make them loosen. "Believing was not required after the first year. Standing was."

She is close enough that two steps would put my mouth at her temple. The ache to do it is stupid and total. She despises the uniform. If I cross the step she will read it as a grab, and she will be half right. The other half is a thing I will not spend where a blade can answer it.

"AE-701," she says, quiet, as if she pulled it off my face. "That's what they called the boy."

"Don't use it."

"I won't." She looks at the violet sky, not at me. "I wanted to know if you still heard it."

I hear it. I also hear her breath, and the shortwave staying dead, and the order I already broke sitting in the sand with a body I did not produce. I keep the step between us. The want stays on my side of it.

CHAPTER 18

TSUNARI

> ***Culture Lab 4.*** *The clean rooms inside the dome where the company does its living work. The people at those benches are told the work is a kindness.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The radar tick is wrong. Not the shortwave. The post's own set, the one that listens for company traffic whether he wants it or not.

"Down," he says. "Unannounced. South road. You do not exist in this room."

The vent is a crawl, not a room. I go in on my forearms, slate hugged to the ribs, the hook handles knocking once until I pin them with my wrists. Hot metal. Grit in the teeth. My shoulders fit because I make them fit. Behind me he seats the grate. Boots on concrete. His voice, level, talking to nobody yet.

I find the relay junction by the heat of it. The Bodkin's tang seats in a service jack Drew would recognize. The slate wakes, face toward me, blue tell covered by my glove. No broadcast. A copy, if I am stupid enough to take one. I am not here to take one. I am here to see who is looking.

Lines fill the glass. A telemetry audit. His post. His fever numbers from the hour he stood six feet off me. And under the packet, the hand that filed it.

Analyst: Tech-Specialist S. Thorne. Culture Lab 4.

The shaft goes small. I know the initial. I cut the rest of her name off an open set two nights ago and it has been living in my mouth ever since. She is not only alive at a bench. She is reading him. The spike. The quiet I will

not name. She will flag it because that is what a careful girl does with a number that looks like a fault, and the flag will walk back down this road with soldiers.

I kill the slate. I do not take the file. A file on my chest is a thing they can find if they open the vent. The signature is already in me, which is worse.

Above, a shadow crosses the slit of sky at the end of the duct. Wings, narrower than his, a patrol span catching the searchlight once and gone. Hawks. They are early, or I am late.

"Clear the pad," a voice says, not his. Company. Close.

I stay in the dark with my sister's initial burning behind my eyes, and I do not answer him, and I do not explain her to the metal. She thinks the work is a kindness. The audit in my hand says the kindness has my hunter's name on it.

CHAPTER 19

SORA

> *The new mist will help the people outside breathe clean again.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The quad smells like jasmine because the building pays for jasmine. I badge through the gate with wet hair and a coat that is actually white, and the tram is already there, bright, no silt on the rail.

Sector 2 slides past the glass. Gardens. A court. People who do not pull cloth over their mouths. I drink from the canteen because the water is real and because the shift will not let me later. Twelve hours. Supervisor Keene counts the minutes between benches. My hands crack anyway, from the wash.

Culture Lab 4 is the same clean light the holos use when they talk about the sky. I hang the coat. I glove. The queue is already moving.

"Thorne. Packet twelve. Don't admire it."

"Yes, ma'am."

Packet twelve is a telemetry strip from a south post. Commander. Avian. Fever trace, then a flatline in the noise, then the fever again. I flag the spike because a spike is the job. The note I attach is three words. Anomaly. Repeat. Review. I do not know the man. I know the form.

On the bench beside the queue, the mist trial sits in a sealed tray. Supervisor Keene tapped it yesterday and said the line we are allowed to say. The new mist will help the people outside breathe clean again. I believe her. The work is ugly in the hands and kind in the purpose. That is what they told me when they took me in. My father was a terrorist who

died of his own foolishness. My sister died of the Choke in the gutter years ago. I was the one who could be taught.

I file the flag. I wash. The crack in my knuckle stings and I do not pick it. When the shift bell goes, I ride the tram back to the quad, eat the meal they issue, and sleep with the white coat on the chair.

I do not go near a ledge. I do not look south. The people outside are a kindness I am making with my hands, and the spike is only a number that wanted a second look.

CHAPTER 20

VRAM

> **A *retrieval.*** *Collared soldiers, sent when the Spire wants a body and will not come down to take it. This one is a Wolf and two Rhinos. A Wolf follows a scent. A Rhino is hide, a horn, and a short charge.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The harvester stays on the horizon. It does not land. What lands is a prowler, government gray, kicking grit across the pad.

Three of them step out. Directorate kit. Sockets in the necks, fitted and ordinary. No black in the veins. No fire along a wing, because two of them have no wings.

The Wolf is first. Narrow, nose already working, ears tucked to the wind off the post. Behind him, two Rhinos. Hide on the neck and the shoulders, a horn each, short legs built to arrive once and hard. One of them is a woman. She looks at the vault grate the way a fighter looks at a door she means to own. The other puts himself where the grate's hinge is, and I understand the shape before anyone speaks. She will charge. He will wedge.

"Commander Tyage," the Wolf says. "Audit and a search. Open the post."

"The runner is dead. I reported the weather."

"We aren't here for the weather." His head turns a fraction. The nose does the rest. "There is a second body in this building. Ducts. Recent. Fear and copper and a woman."

The leash climbs because she is in the shaft and my wrist is empty. Heat stacks behind the eyes. I keep my hands open, the wing half-spread,

so they see the argument and not a measure.

"You have an audit," I say. "You do not have a warrant to gut my post because a nose is bored."

The woman Rhino smiles with no humor in it. "We have a retrieval. Telemetry, and whatever made your numbers lie. Step off the grate, Commander, or I stop asking."

I do not step off. The Wolf is already walking toward the intake, and the woman rolls the shoulder under the plate, and the leash keeps climbing, and I am still trying to talk because the moment I draw their blood I am no longer a commander having a bad week. I am deserted, and the wing I left in the sky can be turned up until it cooks.

"Stand down," I say.

The Wolf does not. He has the scent. He goes into the shaft.

CHAPTER 21

TSUNARI

> ***Plate.*** *The hide on a Rhino's neck, shoulders, and back. A knife skips off it. The chest and the eyes are bare.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The shaft is one body wide. I am that body until the Wolf decides he is too.

He comes up the intake on all the quiet a heavy man can buy. Nose first. I hear the breath change when he finds me. The jaw is the threat, not a lecture I need. I kick off the wall, membranes wiping the grit once, and the leap puts me above his shoulders before the teeth arrive. The hook's beak finds the seam under his ear, not the socket, the strap. He slams me into the metal anyway. Strength. Endurance. The shaft rings.

"Here," he shouts back, voice thick. "She's here."

A charge answers him from the grate. The woman. I don't see her. I hear the horn hit the frame and stick. Somebody else is in the hinge, holding it open and shut at once, a wedge with a body. The charge dies in the geometry. Plate scrapes. She cannot get the shoulders through.

The Wolf surges. I put the Bodkin at the soft of his throat and he twists so the hide of his collar takes it. Wrong class. The hide I need is above us, and it is not on the chest.

I drop under his reach, boots on the duct wall, and I go for the grate at the angle the wedge did not close. The woman Rhino is jammed at the shoulders. Neck plate. Back plate. The chest below the plate is skin, heaving, and the eyes above the horn are bare. The hook skips off the hide with a sound like a bad coin. I do not try the hide again. I rake the beak

across the gap at the collarbone, shallow, enough to make her choose her hands.

She chooses wrong. The wedge slips. I am past her hip and into the mechanical room before the horn comes free.

No stutter. No quiet sent on purpose. I am only fast in a tube and small where they are wide. They are heavier in the doorway, and the doorway is behind me now, and the Wolf is still in the shaft with my scent in his mouth.

"Move," I tell myself, and I move, because the wing I came here with is still upstairs trying to be a commander, and the blood I just drew on a government soldier has already ended that.

CHAPTER 22

VRAM

> ***Desertion.*** *Draw blood on your own government's retrieval, and you are deserted the same hour. They can turn the leash up on the wing you left.*

❖ ❖ ❖

I hear her in the shaft. Then I hear the horn stuck in the frame. The talking part of the hour ends.

I drop through the ceiling on the wing. The mechanical room takes the feathers badly. The woman Rhino is half out of the grate, plate scored, chest bare where the hide stops, eyes up. She is the one who charges. She charges me.

The horn comes for the center of my mass. I leave the floor. The wing catches a beam and throws me sideways, and my hands find the gap her plate does not cover, under the arms, where the hide becomes skin. Heat goes into the grip. The vane along my forearm, the one that lifts when the beat is hard, lays a line across the unplated chest. She bellows. The charge breaks because a charge needs a target that stays on the ground.

The other Rhino is still in the hinge, trying to wedge and fight at once. He gets one arm free. I put a boot on the plate of his shoulder and the wing does the rest, a short ugly fold that cracks him into the frame. The Wolf comes out of the shaft last, bleeding at the strap, nose full of her. I meet him with the heat still in my hands. He goes down on the knee and stays, because a Wolf who cannot trust his nose will not spend the jaw.

She is against the far wall, hooks low, breathing hard, eyes on me like she is waiting to see what I am now.

I know what I am. Their blood is on the grate. Directorate kit. My kit, an hour ago. Draw blood on your own retrieval and the desertion is the same hour. They can turn the leash up on Cassian, on Toby, on Rook, on Amari, until the wing I taught them cooks for my choice.

The leash tries. A stitch, then a climb. Her hand finds my wrist without asking, and the climb stops, and that is a second crime stacked on the first.

"You drew on them," she says.

"So did you."

"Then we are both already gone." She does not thank me. "Get us off this floor before the next prowler learns how."

I look at the soldiers on the concrete. Alive. Down. Government. The life that gave me the wing is on the floor with them. I take her hand off my wrist only when I can stand the noise long enough to walk.

CHAPTER 23

CORVUS

> *Both of them. Alive. We need to understand what happened.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The lab keeps my face at thirty. I am eighty, and I know which hour the last treatment bought, and I do not spend that hour on a mirror. The mirror is for other people.

The voice comes through the ceiling array, not a body in the room. Karyon. Patient. The glass of nothing fogs, because there is no sleeve here, only a speaker and my clean air.

"Your soldier's return dropped," it says. "The noise left him and came back. A woman was on the contact. She is the anomaly. Priority zero. Both of them. Alive. We need to understand what happened."

"A name for the anomaly."

"No."

"A mechanism."

"No. Capture. Do not open her on the road. A corpse cannot be read, and a commander cooked in a ditch is a story you already tried to tell me. I disliked it."

I stand at my own bench in my own lab and I am being used as staff. The anger is clean and useful. Vanity sits under it: he is my weapon, my beautiful work, and a dirty girl in a collar put her hand on him and he chose her. Tired sits under the vanity. The cohort I will spend is young, and the leash will hurt them, and I will sign the hurt because the alternative is to be the director who lost the masterwork.

"Alive," I say. "Both. I'll send the wing he left, and a retrieval behind it. If he bleeds them, the gain stays up until he comes home or the wing fails. He will understand the price."

"Do not diagnose him over the beam."

"I don't have a diagnosis," I say, and the truth of that tastes like an insult. "I have an order."

The voice leaves. The lab is white and mine again. I look thirty. I feel the hour. I call the roost myself, because a woman who lets a secretary spend her weapon is already retired.

"South post. Both alive. Bring them in readable." I pause, and the pause is not kindness. "And tell his brother nothing he can use. Weather is over."

THE STERILE ROOM

Dr. Alistair Vance washes his hands a fifth time. The water is warm. The soap is unscented. The skin at the knuckles splits anyway, a thin red line, and he watches it the way he watches a suture that has not decided to hold.

He is fifty-two. Senior cardiovascular surgeon. Eden Dome Alpha, the gilded tier. Today he took a heart out of a man the Directorate had finished with and put it into a director who had not. The gallery called it a success. The gallery always does.

The penthouse is white stone and a bowl of fruit that was grown on purpose. Filtered air. No silt on the rail. He sets the silver scalpels in their case, each edge already clean, and he polishes them until his face appears in the steel and looks like a man who has earned the room.

The wine is synthetic. He pours it. He puts it in his mouth. He cannot taste it. He swallows because the ritual is the point, not the pleasure. Pleasure left with the first year of this life, or with the tenth heart, he does not keep the count in a place he visits.

On the balcony the gardens shine under the shield. Five hundred feet down, the lower terraces are still beautiful. He stands on the ledge in his socks. One hand on the rail. The other hanging open, the split knuckle drying.

He thinks of his brother in nothing. He has a practice, not a barracks. The boy with the cream wings is somebody else's sentence.

Alistair leans out until the wind of the shield's vents touches his teeth. He does not step. He goes back inside. He washes the hands a sixth time. The blood beads, small and precise, and the penthouse keeps its silence, which is the only thing in the room he still recognizes.

CHAPTER 24

TSUNARI

> *Feather to feather, bone to bone None of the Aerie falls alone. Break the wind and ride the squall If one must dive, we catch the fall.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The pad fills with lights. Hawks in the air, narrower than the shadow I already know, and ground lamps on the south lip. He does not give me a speech. He buckles the spare harness across his chest and pulls me into it until my thighs have to lock at his hips or drag.

"Hold," he says. "Eyes shut when the lamps hit. If you let go, the band gets you and I do not get a second grab."

"I don't shut my eyes for men who give orders."

"Shut them for the glare." His arm locks behind my back. The plate of his chest is heat through the cloth. Every shift of the strap moves us against each other, a fact neither of us has time to file and both of us feel. My arms go around his neck because the alternative is the concrete.

Searchlights pin the post. A voice on his old channel starts a cadence I do not know and will not repeat. He cuts the channel with his jaw.

"They'll fire," I say.

"Some of them will miss on purpose. Don't count on it."

He steps off the lip.

The stomach goes first. Then the wing bites, and the ground becomes a dark band with chemical sheen, and the terror and the safety arrive in the same breath. I am locked to a soldier I fought in a shack. I am also not falling. His heartbeat is a drum against my ribs. The harness creaks. I hold.

"Breathe," he says into my hair.

"I am."

A flare opens behind us. The squad is up. I see one span of them against the lamps, a line of Hawks, and then I stop looking at the measure of anything. The yard is a rumor of containers on the far side of the band. His arms stay locked. I hate how much of my weight I have given him, and I do not let go.

CHAPTER 25

VRAM

> *You do not fire on your own wing.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The dead band is a few miles of bad ground and a rim of pale lakebed. I have her locked to my chest and the wing is doing two jobs. Fly. Don't crush her.

Cassian is on my left, Hawk, patrol span, the man I told to hold a roost. He does not fire. I see the hesitation in the way his hands stay open. He was told a weather report. He was told a corpse. He is looking at a living woman in my harness and the order in his skull, and the order is losing by a second at a time.

"Commander," he says on the channel. "Land and I can still call this a return."

"You can't."

Rook comes in hot on the right, irreverent even now, and the slug he sends goes wide into the haze. "Targeting optics full of dust!" he shouts, for the log, for whoever is counting loyalty. The next shot is wide too. He is a Hawk. He does not miss twice unless he means to.

Toby dives. Cream and rust. Younger. He puts his body between a flak drone and the root of my wing, slipstream ugly, a Hawk's tuck with no lecture in it. The drone's burst chews his vane instead of my bone. He swears, soft, the way he apologizes.

"You do not fire on your own wing," I tell the channel, and I am the one who made the sentence a lie by leaving.

Amari is a wheat flicker higher up, not shooting. Cassian still has not. The leash on all of them will be climbing because Corvus does not like a hesitation. I feel mine try to climb and her palm, trapped between us, keeps it from finishing.

"Yard," she says against my throat. "I see containers."

"Then we get there before a honest gun does."

Rook laughs once, broken. "Fly, Commander. I'll keep missing."

I beat. The band streams under us. Toby bleeds light into the haze and stays in my shadow anyway, because he is Vance and he is my wing, and Cassian follows without firing, which is the last kindness he can afford me.

CHAPTER 26

TSUNARI

> *The dust gets into the seals, the teeth, the lungs. When the sun goes, the cold bites harder than the dogs. If you leave the dome, don't look up. The sky out here is waiting.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The air is a fist.

I have never been in it like this. Roofs, gantries, the long fall off a flange my knees could eat. Not a wing. The harness holds me to his chest and the wing does the rest, a violence of muscle and feather that should not be able to lift two people and does.

Flak opens in the chemical haze, soft ugly flowers. Grit hits my teeth. I taste the band and I do not have a hand free to cover my mouth. His shoulder is a burn against my cheek. I cling and I am furious that clinging is the correct choice.

"Don't look up," I tell myself, which is a dead man's advice from a road I am no longer on. I look. The sky out here is bigger than the wall. Copper, then a tear of searchlight, then his primaries cutting it. Black. A hard beat throws a blue-violet sheen along the shafts and it is gone. I am terrified. I am also, for one heartbeat, sure of the shape of what they built him to do. Not a speech. A fact with wind in it.

"Yard," he says.

I see it. Containers. One ruin on the lakebed, not a second country, not a horizon of dunes I would have to name. Close. The flight is a few miles and my stomach has already spent them.

A slug snaps past his knee. Rook, or not Rook. I don't ask. I lock my ankles and I keep my eyes open, because if we fall I want to see the ground that takes us.

"If you drop me," I say, "I will haunt the wing."

"I'm not dropping you." His arm tightens. The safety and the terror stay braided. "Hold through the flare. Then we are down, and down is a problem I know."

CHAPTER 27

VRAM

> ***The dead band.*** *A poisoned strip at the edge of the ring, hosed so nothing grows out. Past it, one ruin: the freight yard. Containers, a drain, a basement.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The turrets wake when we cross the lip of the band.

Phosphor. A hose of it, not rain, a chemical line that eats color out of the air. I roll. The roll puts her under the wing for one second and the next second the shrapnel finds the left vane. Pain is a white nail through the root. Feathers tear. The beat staggers.

"Down," I say, which is not a choice anymore.

She doesn't scream. She locks harder. The yard comes up too fast: containers, a black mouth of drain between them, the lakebed rim. I aim for the mouth because the pad of the yard is a place guns can finish. The drain is a guess.

We hit water that is not water. Cold, chemical, a slam. The harness buckle tears skin at my ribs. She comes off my chest only because I rip the strap before we drown in a pipe. The wing drags. I haul her onto a dry ledge above the wash by the harness webbing and then by the wrist.

One ruin. The freight yard is over our heads. I can hear grit ticking on containers. About ten miles south of the mast, if the map in my skull survived the hose. No second desert. No far country. The basement of this place, if it has one, is under the same floor.

"You're hit," she says.

"The wing." I look at the shredded vane and the blood threading into the chemical film. "We stay in the drain until the lights pass. Then we find a hole that is not a turret's idea of a hole."

Above us, a Hawk calls my name once. Cassian. I do not answer. Answering paints the pipe. I put my back to the concrete and I let the torn wing shake, and I do not try to fly.

CHAPTER 28

TSUNARI

> *Water will not stop the burn. The clothes have to come off, and the skin has to be scraped. Shame is slower than the burn.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The chemical keeps eating after we are out of it.

His shirt smokes at the hem. My tunic, the sleeve, the wrap at my thigh, all of it holds the burn against the skin. I strip the cloth because the alternative is a wound that finishes the job the hose started. He does the same, jaw locked, no speech about modesty. Shame can wait. The burn will not.

Cold in the culvert. His skin throws heat anyway. I scrape the dust and the scorched down off the root where the wing leaves his back, fingers careful, because the quills are live and the flesh around them flinches like a nerve. He makes a sound he does not mean to make. Not pain only. The root answers the touch. His whole back tightens. His hands find the stone and the knuckles go white once, and then he is turning, crowding me to the wall, breath wrecked.

"Stop," he says, and his mouth is already at my throat. "Or don't. Tell me which."

"The burn is off." My voice is not steady. His hands are on my hips, hot, shaking, asking by staying. "The rest of this, you ask."

"I'm asking."

I nod, once, because I want it and because I will not pretend the want is only his. He goes to his knees on the wet stone. Mouth, then fingers, specific and unhurried and nothing like the fight in the shack. The cold of

the culvert and the heat of him. I brace on his shoulder. The wing curves in, not a cage, a wall against the dark. I come apart against his mouth with his name caught in my teeth, and he stays until the shake leaves my legs.

He pulls back before the rest. His forehead rests on my stomach. He is hard against his own thigh and he does not chase it.

"If I keep going I will burn you," he says. "The heat doesn't know the difference between a wing and a body. I do."

"Then we stop." I get my hand in his hair, not a reward, a fact. "You stopped. Remember that you stopped."

We breathe. The clothes are a ruined pile. The burn is a lesser hurt. I am aching and clear-headed, and the addiction is already in the place where the ache is, and I do not give it a softer name than want.

CHAPTER 29

VRAM

> ***The furnace.*** *The heat that flies the wing. Tear the wing and leave him on the ground, and the heat has nowhere to go but into him.*

❖ ❖ ❖

I try to lift us off the yard at dusk, when the lights have gone to the lip and the containers are a maze I can use.

The wing will not hold. The torn vane spills air. The shoulder goes with a sound I feel in my teeth. We hop a container, then the beat fails, and I drop us back into the aisle with my body between her and the grit. The heat that should have gone into the sky stays in the chest. It climbs. Past the standing fever. Past the number I can think through.

"Don't," she says, hand on my sternum. The quiet tries to arrive and the pain rides over it. This hurt is the leash and the torn root agreeing. "You fly that and you spill us."

"I know."

There is no second country to reach. The ruin is the country. Containers. The drain we climbed out of. A basement smell from a seam in the foundation, someone else's cache, not a road. Kira's name is a rumor I do not spend. Boran's door is a story soldiers tell. Under this yard, if the stories are true. I cannot dig a story with one wing.

The fever crests and my vision tightens. She pushes me down against a container wall and keeps the hand on me, and the mesh goes softer without going kind. I am still burning.

"Listen," I say. "If I stop making sense, you take the slate and you go north by the wall. You do not stay to argue with a man who is cooking."

"I don't take orders from a fever." Her palm stays. "We wait for the wing to remember it is a wing. Until then you are cover, not a plan."

I laugh once. It hurts. The yard ticks. Far off, a dog barks and then thinks better of it. I put my head back against the metal and I let her be the one who is right, and the heat stays in me, looking for a sky it cannot have.

THE QUOTA CALCULATION

The beef is real. The strawberries are real. The wine is not the synthetic kind Alistair Vance cannot taste. High Chancellor Julian Ward cuts a piece, chews, and listens to his daughter tell him about a horse that does not exist outside the garden program.

His wife is pregnant and luminous in the shield-light. The penthouse faces the inner courts. She wants the athletic field wider. The gardeners want the roses to have a margin. The quarterly sheet in his lap is how those wants become weather for people none of them will meet.

Sector 09, downwind wards. He can pull the lee back by a street and a half. The inner field gets its width. Four thousand people lose the spill. Their afternoons become silt. Their cellars pool after dark. He knows what starts in those blocks when the easy air leaves. He does not say the word at the table.

"The balance holds if the outer band gives," he says, to the sheet, not to his wife.

"Will anyone be angry?" she asks, which means will anyone who can reach this room be angry.

"No one who is invited to dinner."

He signs. The pen is heavy. The signature is small. He wipes his mouth with a linen napkin, leans over, and kisses his daughter's forehead. She smells like strawberries. She tells him the horse's name.

"My blood survives," he says, soft enough that she thinks it is affection. "The rest is arithmetic."

He pours his wife another glass. The sheet goes into the case. Somewhere south of the glass, four thousand evenings change, and the man who changed them asks his daughter whether the horse will be white.

CHAPTER 30

REN

> ***The rattle.*** *The dry sound behind the breastbone. It can go on for years before the lungs turn to glass. It is already in his chest.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The cut link is still in my ear when I tell Drew I am going.

She is at the bench. The tang she wrapped for Tsune is still on the cloth, useless, because the woman who uses it did not come home. T.J. is in the set, fourteen and furious in the only way he allows, which is precision.

"Bearing is south," he says. "Past the mirrors. I am not coming up. Ask me again and I will stop answering."

"I'm not asking you," I say. "I'm telling her."

Drew looks at the burn on her hand. "She told us to turn around."

"She told us that so we would live. I spent the night living. I'm done."

The rattle clicks when I stand. One dry catch behind the breastbone. Drew hears it and puts a cartridge on the bench without a speech. I hate that she is right. I take it.

We take the cart because she will not let me walk it. The lee thins. The mirrors go by, black and already a lie we will tell if we have to. I count the roofs, then the miles, because counting is what I can do while my chest does the other thing. The dead band is a mile of air I should not breathe. I breathe it with the cartridge in my teeth and I do not thank her.

The freight yard is containers and a quiet that has dogs in it. I want to climb down. I get one boot on the rim.

Tsune is there, small, between the boxes, blood on her sleeve and a page in her hand. She looks at me the way she looks at a window that is about to close.

"No," she says.

"We came to..."

"You came to go back." She puts the page in Drew's hand. "Mercer hears you lost the signal at the mirrors. T.J. stays down. You do not climb. You do not look for the hole under this yard. You do not look for the man."

"What man?"

"The one you are not going to see." Her eyes stay on mine until my boot comes back up. "Go, Ren. If you stay, I spend the minute I need on you."

I go. The rattle keeps time. I do not see a drain. I do not see a face past the containers. I see her until the rim takes her, and then I see the road, and I hate every yard of it that is the right direction.

CHAPTER 31

TSUNARI

> **A *pack.*** *Feral dogs. They are not soldiers, and they do not answer a voice. Run, and you are food.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The yard goes quiet the way a hunt goes quiet.

I drag him by the harness webbing into a container that still has a door. He is half here, wing leaving a dark trail, heat pouring off him in a sheet. The fever is past talking. I get the door half shut and I listen. No boots. Paws. A pack, not a patrol. Dogs. If I run they will commit. If I speak to them like they are a tool, I am food with opinions.

The rim of the yard shows two shapes I know. Drew's cart. Ren beside it, too tall and too young and already leaning down.

I meet them at the lip before he can climb. The page is the schedule skin, the fourteen months, copied small. I put it in Drew's hand.

"Back," I say. "Tell Mercer you lost the signal at the mirrors. Tell T.J. the bearing is done and the hole stays his."

"You're bleeding," Drew says.

"I'm standing. He isn't, and that is not your problem to see." I look at Ren until his boot retreats. "You do not come into the yard. You do not look under it. Go."

Ren's mouth opens. The look I give him closes it. They turn the cart. I watch until the band takes them. They will lie, and the lie will keep the clinic, and I will hate the lie later if there is a later.

A dog trots the aisle, ribs, yellow eye, interested. I do not speak. I step back into the container and pull the door to a slit. Vram's breath is a rasp.

The pack is arranging itself. The lead one is larger, and it has decided the slit is a door.

I put the Bodkin in my hand and I wait, because running is the mistake, and calling is the other mistake, and the animal in the gap is not a soldier I can bargain with.

CHAPTER 32

TSUNARI

The lead dog comes through the slit as if the metal were a suggestion.

I have no name for what my body does next.

The rush is a shoulder and teeth. I should be under it. I am beside it, one step that did not take the time a step takes, the container skipping like a bad frame. The dog hits the wall where I was. I am already at its shoulder. The Bodkin goes in behind the blade of the shoulder, deep enough to turn the charge, not a speech, a puncture.

It snarls and rounds. I do the thing again because the thing is happening, not because I chose a word for it. Ghost is the wrong word. I am still here. The timing is not. The teeth close on air. I am at the door seam, heart too loud, the move already gone, as if it spent itself and left me the bill.

"Stay down," I tell Vram, useless, because he is trying to rise and the wing will not let him.

The dog is not dead. It is offended and bleeding and still a dog. The others are in the aisle, waiting to see if the big one finishes its meal. I cannot click them away. I cannot be a master of an animal that does not answer. I can be faster than the next rush for as long as the glitch in my bones lasts, and I do not know the length of that.

The lead one gathers. I set my feet. Somewhere under the fever, his eyes open, and the container is about to be too small for a wing and a pack and a woman who just stepped out of a second she did not have.

CHAPTER 33

VRAM

> **A cache.** *A scavenger's store, marked and kept. Come into it bleeding and you are not a guest. You are a bill.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Her blood is the thing that wakes me. Copper, close, hers.

The lead dog is in the container. I get a hand on its skull and the weight of the wing on its back and I break the rush the ugly way, no fire in the veins, no second engine, just mass and a neck that turns too far. It drops. The pack outside answers. I do not have another of those.

A crawler hits the aisle with its lamps killed and a flare-slug already in the air. Phosphor bursts over the dogs. They scatter, not loyal, hungry and suddenly blind. The woman on the deck has a gun and she does not lower it.

Wolf. I know the set of the shoulders before I know the face. Dark fur along the upper arms, skin at the chest, amber eyes, canines when she speaks. Bare nape. Unregistered, like the woman bleeding beside me, and not on our side because of it.

"This is my cache," she says. "The dogs have been eating it. You are bleeding on it. Give me a reason not to finish what they started."

"Kira Brandt," I say.

"And you are a Raven hot enough to pull a satellite onto my road." The gun stays. She looks at Tsunari's throat, at the absence of a socket, and something in her face changes by a degree and no more. "The heat I can mask. I sell that. I do not haul a collar for free, and I do not haul a page I haven't read."

Tsunari holds out the copy. Her hand shakes. She does not beg. "Fourteen months. The lee over the Ring fails. Evacuation zero. You run freight through that air. Read it before you decide we are a bill you can't afford."

Kira takes the page. She reads. The gun does not dip until the last line.

"Get in," she says. "You pay for the mask with the rest of that file, and you stay where I put you. Boran owes me a door. Two fugitives and a true page clear the debt. He still decides if the bulkhead opens. I don't."

I get Tsunari up. No black veins. No miracle wing. A scavenger, a price, and a crawler that is not the government's. I can live with a bill. I cannot live with the dogs.

CHAPTER 34

TSUNARI

The basement is under the yard and the cold is the kind that kills a sleeper.

Kira put us here and went up to lie to her own road. The cot is narrow. His fever is a stove in a room that wants to be ice. The torn wing will not settle. If I stay on the floor he cooks on one side and freezes on the other. I get on the cot. I wrap around him. Cool skin against the burn of him, the Raptor trick I was taught, taking heat, fixing nothing. It is enough to drop the edge off the fever. His breath evens. The wing tries to cover us and mostly fails and still makes a wall.

When his eyes clear, they are his.

"You should have gone with the boy," he says.

"The boy went. I stayed. Those are different sentences."

He looks at my mouth, at the blood drying at my sleeve, at the fact of us in one blanket of feathers and bad decisions. The want is there. So is the stop he already proved he can make. I put my hand on his chest, over the heat, and I say the line before he can make it pretty.

"Partners, or nothing."

He is quiet long enough that I think the fever took the words. Then his hand covers mine.

"Partners," he says. "Or nothing. I heard you."

"No keeper. No collar with a nicer name. If you fly, I know why. If I run, you know why. We don't spend each other to feel safe."

"Agreed."

He pulls me in under the ruined wing. Not sex. Shelter, and the compact inside it. The cold stays outside the feathers. His mouth touches my hair once, asking nothing. I stay awake until his pulse is a number I can

trust, and the word partners sits between us like a tool we both know how to hold.

CHAPTER 35

VRAM

> ***Off the mesh.*** *The leash is also his map, his orders, and the voices of his wing. When that goes quiet, he is not free. He is blind.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Dawn is a gray line under the yard door. She is asleep on my chest. The wing aches. The fever has backed down to a live coal. The mesh is quiet.

I hate the quiet.

For ten years the noise was the map. Cassian's position. Toby's breath when he was scared and lying about it. Orders. The sting that meant obey. A soldier off the mesh in occupied ground is not at peace. He is a man with his eyes cut out, lying under a scavenger's floor, hoping the wing he abandoned is only in pain and not in a grave he cannot see.

I do not wake her to say that. She would hear it as regret for the compact. It is not. It is the bill.

Kira's boot hits the stair. She looks at the two of us and snorts.

"Romantic. Also visible from a satellite if you keep glowing. The mask is a paste and a route. You wear the paste. You walk when I say. The rail under this yard is a few miles back under the ring, into the south sumps. Not a trek across a country. A trolley, if Boran opens the door. The cult holds the water on the far end. The vault you want is past that water. I don't do vaults."

"The wing," I say. "Can they hear me?"

"Not from here. That's the point, and it's the problem." She tosses a tin. "Eat. Then you tell me whether your girl can walk, because I am not

carrying a Raven up a bulkhead for the pleasure of his guilt."

Tsunari's eyes are open. She heard the last of it. She does not apologize for the quiet. I do not ask her to.

"I can walk," she says.

"Then we walk," I say. The blindness stays. I put it next to the compact and I carry both.

CHAPTER 36

VRAM

> ***The rail under the yard.*** *A few miles of freight line, back under the ring, into the south sumps. The vault is past that water. The cult holds the water.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Boran fills the door before he opens it.

Hide on the face, the neck, the shoulders, the arms. A horn on the brow, heavy, centered. The chest under the plate is bare skin, weathered. No socket. He left that life. He looks at my wing, at the torn vane, at Tsunari standing on her own feet, and he laughs once, a low sound with no welcome in it.

"Fancy fallen flyer," he says. "Clipped. And a girl who hasn't run. Kira says you clear a debt."

"The page is real," Kira says. "The mask is paid. The door is yours."

He grunts. The respect, if it is respect, is for the way I have put my shoulder between Tsunari and the bulkhead, not for the wing. "You shield her like a man who learned something. Fine. The trolley is hand-cranked. The line runs a few miles under the ring and spits you in the south sumps. After that the water belongs to the hymn-singers. I don't walk you into a sermon."

"The vault," Tsunari says.

"Past the water. Gideon's problem. Not mine." He unlocks the brake. The rail smell is old oil and cold stone. "You crank. You don't preach on my line. You don't bleed on the seat if you can help it."

I take the crank. The wing complains. She stands at the lamp and watches the dark ahead, already counting exits. Kira lifts two fingers and is gone up the stair, debt spent, gun still her own.

The trolley moves. A few miles. Then sump water, and a cult, and a room that might tell us what her hand is. I crank. Boran watches the hide of the tunnel the way a man watches ground he intends to keep.

THE FATAL SIPHON

> ***The gain.*** *How hard they drive the leash. When a commander leaves, they can turn it up on the wing he left, and they do not have to turn it down.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Cassian kneels on a roost he no longer reports to.

Fourteen days. The noise never came down. Vram left, and the gain stayed at the top of what a mesh can carry, and the Directorate did not love him enough to lower it. The socket is a coal. The tab bites. His wings open once against the wind, cream-dark in the searchlight, a Hawk's span and no one's rescue, and then they fold because the fold is all he has left that still obeys.

He deserted at dawn. Not toward the girl. Not toward a cause. Away from the channel that was cooking him for another man's choice. The desertion did not turn the gain down. That was the lesson. The lesson is finishing.

No second body wakes in him. No venom. No other strain climbing the bone. There is only the leash, and the leash is enough.

He thinks of Toby, and he does not call. A call would put the boy in the log beside him. He thinks of Rook's wide shots and Amari's dirty wind and a weather report he repeated in a clean voice. He thinks he might have known. The thought arrives too late to be useful.

The burn goes white behind the eyes. The wings shiver once more and go still. The roost does not send a squad to the ledge. Toby does not learn. The wing will be told a desertion, or a storm, or nothing.

Cassian puts his forehead to the stone. The noise peaks. Then the noise, and the man, stop.

CHAPTER 37

CAELIA

> ***The cup.*** *A thin drink of rift vapor, taken at a ceremony. It tips the room and makes a voice seem to speak to one person. It does not change the body. The Forger is the one who says what the voice meant.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The cistern is a church because she says it is.

Brands on the walls. Malakar at the edge of the lamp, watching who drinks and who only pretends. The Forger's voice is flat. She does not need to shout. I am twenty-one and I have been hers since fourteen, and the cup is the kindest thing she gives me that is not a promise.

It is a thin drink. It is not the thing they put in a vein in the back room. My body stays my body. The room tips. The water light moves. A voice seems to speak to me alone, not to the row, not to Malakar. I see a wing on fire and a place at his right hand, and the place has my shape in it.

I wake on the stone with my cheeks wet and the certainty already hard. The vision was mine. I was there.

The Forger crouches. She smells like heat and iron. She puts two fingers under my chin.

"You saw him," she says. "The flame that falls. You stand at his right hand, or the flame goes out, and you go out with it. The cold one on the road is the hand that would smother him. You will not let her."

I nod. I am not performing. I love the sentence the way a starved girl loves a door. He will know me. He will take my hand. The other woman is a

problem I am allowed to hate.

Malakar's eyes say he heard the reading and filed me under tools. I do not care. The Forger has told me what the voice meant. That is the hold, and it feels like being chosen.

I stand. I am already walking toward the water where they will be. The ambush can wait for my feet. The faith cannot.

CHAPTER 38

TSUNARI

> ***An Ember.*** *One of the few who survived what the cult puts in a vein. Strong past sense, hot, and sure. The pain at the edges of the body has been burned almost away.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The sump water is knee-deep and the wrong kind of warm.

We are off the rail. The vault is a direction, not a door yet. The first body drops from a side pipe without a splash she bothers to hide. Young. Hot. Sure. A brand at her throat. She looks at Vram the way a person looks at a story that has walked into her house, and then she looks at me the way a person looks at a stain.

"Cold Serpent," she says. "You don't get to put him out."

"Caelia," he says, a warning. He knows the name from a sermon he hasn't sat through. She does not take the warning.

She is strong past sense. The pain at the edges of her is gone, burned off, and what is left is fast and happy to spend itself. She hits me in the water. I go under and come up with a hook in my hand. Her skin is fever-hot. Mine takes some of it and gives nothing back she can use. She laughs.

"He falls from the sky and you crawl next to him like a leash. I was promised the right hand."

"You were promised a sentence," I say, and I slam her into the pipe wall. She doesn't drop. Embers don't drop for a shove. Two more are in the tunnel behind her, brands, the same burned-clean eyes.

Vram is still ten paces back, wing dragging, the crank-hours in his shoulder. She wants me dead before he arrives so the story can be clean. I

do not let the story get clean. I put the tunnel between her and a straight rush, and I bleed from the lip where her knuckle found me, and I stay on my feet.

"Come and smother him, then," she says. "I'll cut the hand off before it touches his fire."

Black feathers shift in the dark behind me. She sees them and her face opens into joy. I see the joy and I know the fight just changed owners.

CHAPTER 39

VRAM

> *The fire will know you. He will take your hand.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Her blood is on her mouth. That is the fact. The rest of the tunnel can wait.

I hit the first Ember with the wing and the second with the heel of my hand. They are hot and sure and they are not me. Caelia drops to her knees in the water when she sees my face. The brand at her throat shines. She is twenty-one and incandescent with a story.

"You know me," she says. "The fire knows you. Take my hand. I was told I stand at your right."

"You were told wrong." I shove her aside, not cruel for sport, firm enough that she has to catch herself on the wall. "She is bleeding. You did that. Move."

I get Tsunari's chin in my fingers and check the lip, the teeth, the eye. The cut is small and the rage in me is not. Caelia makes a sound like a sob and a snarl braided.

"She is the cold. She puts the light out. I saw it. The Forger said..."

"I don't take the name you're offering." I do not look at her. My hand stays gentle on Tsunari and hard everywhere else. "Promised king is a collar. I have worn one. I am not shopping for a second."

Caelia's eyes burn. Jealousy, faith, the insult of being moved aside for a woman in a torn tunic. She will remember the shove. I will remember the blood.

"Can you walk?" I ask Tsunari.

"I was walking before you arrived." Her voice shakes and she hates it. "Don't make her a project. Make us a direction."

"The vault," I say. "Through them if they stand in it."

Caelia stays on her knees as we pass. She does not attack again. She watches my hand on Tsunari's back, and the watching is worse than a knife, because it is patient.

CHAPTER 40

VRAM

> *Iron that fears the hammer stays slag. Flesh that fears the fire stays mortal. Bow your neck to the anvil, or be swept out with the waste.*

❖ ❖ ❖

They escort us because killing us in a pipe would waste the audience.

The Grand Cistern is a temple made of industry. Water, iron, thousands kneeling. The Forger stands where the sound carries. Malakar stands at her shoulder with a rail-flail across his back, the pneumatic hiss of it once, then quiet. Her chest is bare above the brands, once, and I look at her eyes instead.

"Deliverer," she says. The flat voice from Caelia's faith, life-size. "The dome took your name and your wing and gave you a leash. I will give you an army. She..." a flick at Caelia, shining and wrecked, "...is the right hand. The cold one is the price. We cut her here, and the flame stays lit."

Tsunari does not kneel. I feel her counting exits. I do not take the army. I do not take the girl. I spit the sentence so the cistern can keep it.

"She is not my bride, and I am no one's god."

The kneelers make a sound like a wound. Malakar's flail shifts. The Forger's face does not. She has spent fifteen years telling grieving people that the thing which stole their children is the forge that brings one home. I am the one, in her mouth. I am refusing the mouth.

"Then you are slag," she says. "And slag gets swept."

"Sweep," I say.

Caelia stares at me as if I have set fire to her house from the inside. Malakar roars. The flail needs room, and the catwalks have room, and

Tsunari is already moving, which is the only prayer I trust.

CHAPTER 41

TSUNARI

> **A *rail-flail.*** *Iron on a spring, built to break a body that can fly. It needs room. A falling gate does not give it room.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Malakar needs a stage. I take the stage away.

The flail is a length of iron on a spring, pneumatic once as it arms, hungry for space. He swings at Vram's wing and the catwalk rings. I am not in that swing. I am at the sluice winch with the last charge Drew packed for a door, an acoustic pop, ugly and small. The gate above Malakar complains. Then it falls.

Iron fills the room the flail wanted. He has to fold the weapon or lose the arm. He folds. We run.

The aqueduct after that is a throat. We hit a bend and have to stop chest to chest, his wing jammed, my hooks against his ribs, both of us breathing the same bad air. His mouth is close enough that the kiss is a fact we do not spend. His hand stays on the wall beside my head. Mine stays on the slate strap. A held breath. The want is enormous. The exit is behind his shoulder, and the exit wins.

"Not here," I say.

"No." He is shaking with the fight and with the not-kiss. "Partners. The word still stands."

"It stands. Move."

We move. Behind us the cistern is a roar of people who wanted a god and got a fallen gate. Ahead, the dark goes toward a market, smoke and voices, a walk, not a new city. I keep the charge's aftertaste in my teeth

and the almost of his mouth in a place I will not open until a room has a second door.

CHAPTER 42

TSUNARI

> *The stills fill at dawn, and the shelters open when the freeze drops. No house takes the lee for itself.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Ren finds us at the edge of the south water because of course he does. He should be at the clinic. He is on a roof with a cloth over his mouth and the rattle hidden badly.

"Don't," I say.

"I'm the introduction," he says. "Then I leave. She won't talk to a wing she hasn't priced."

Madame Vrena Chen keeps a stall that is actually a government. Baseline. Gray at the temples. She looks at the sky the way a person looks at a thing they remember in another color. One line of that is enough. She was alive before the copper. She sells nothing sentimental.

"Stills at dawn," she says. "Shelters when the freeze drops. You want hours, parts, and a centrifuge that isn't a toy. He wants forgiveness for sweeps I still have on a wall."

Vram stands where she can see his hands. "I flew those sweeps. I won't retell them. If you need a man to hate, use me and still sell her the hours. The lee over this market fails in fourteen months. The page is in her sling. Read it before you decide we are a raid."

Chen reads. The market moves around us. Ren shifts and I put two fingers on his wrist, the old signal for go home. He goes, this time, because Chen's people are watching and he is not stupid in a crowd.

"No house takes the lee for itself," Chen says. "You don't get a private sky. You get the stills on the common clock, a shelter bench, and the parts if your Raven hauls them without breaking my pipes. He looks at me when I speak. He does not look at the girls. That is the beginning of a respect, not the end of a debt."

"We'll haul," I say.

"You'll haul at dawn." She folds the page and gives it back. "And you'll tell the boy with the bad lungs that my roof is not a hallway."

CHAPTER 43

VRAM

> ***The dose.*** *What they drink at the altar only tips the mind. What they put in a vein in the back room is what makes an Ember. Few live through it.*

❖ ❖ ❖

We go back for the proof because Chen's hours will not matter if the sump is building an army in a closet.

The distillation room is behind the cistern we fled. Quiet now. The altar cup is a stain on a bench. I do not replay Caelia's ceremony. I know what a thin drink does. It tips a mind. It does not make the thing that hit Tsunari in the water.

The back room is the needle. A cot with restraints. A tray. A recorder left in a hurry, optical, still warm. Tsunari seats a lead and the slate drinks the file without broadcasting it.

Malakar, younger by a year on the image, screaming while something goes into the vein. The scream changes. What stands up is stronger, hotter, sure, the pain burned off the edges. An Ember. The tray beside the cot has three more restraints and two empty ones. A handful. Not a nation. Suicidal shock troops, made in a room we were dragged past.

"Few live through it," she says.

"He lived. She lived. The rest are the kneelers, or the dead." I pocket nothing. The copy sits in her slate. "We don't drink it. We don't carry the needle. We carry the picture."

A step in the hall. We kill the slate's tell. The step goes on, a patrol that is bored. We leave by the pipe we came in, the recording against her ribs,

the altar behind us doing what altars do when nobody is performing.

The vault is next, if Gideon still keeps a door. The cult's secret is already in our hands, small and filthy and enough.

CHAPTER 44

VRAM

> **A *curator.*** *Someone who keeps the old record and does not sell it to the dome or the cult. The Vault is that room, under the ring.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Eighty feet under Sector 09, the door is glass and iron. Cut into the lintel, in letters a torch can read: *What is written in light cannot be erased by fire.* Older than the company. Older than the wing they told me was a patent.

Gideon Cross is a thin man with archive dust on his cuffs and no socket. He does not bow. He looks at the torn vane, at her collar, at the slate, and he decides we are not a raid.

"You want the record," he says. "The record is not a weapon you swing today. Come in before the sump remembers it has legs."

The Vault smells like cold glass and paper that survived. He unrolls a codex. Winged hunters, cut into stone long before Apex had a name. My stomach drops in a way the fever never managed.

"They told me I was made in a lab," I say.

"You were finished in a lab," Gideon says. "The sentence is older. The company owns the socket and the story. It does not own the first cut of the bone."

Tsunari watches my face, not the codex. She is letting me have the blow. The five strains in her blood are not this page. This page is mine. I am not an unholy accident that started when a director wanted a hawk. Something in the bone was walking around before they put a number on a boy in a Ring ward.

"Sovereignty is a large word," I say.

"Then use a small one," she says. "Yours."

I put my hand on the glass over the drawing. The wing shifts, torn and still mine. Gideon rolls the codex shut with the care of a man who does not sell what he keeps.

"There is more," he says. "It will hurt her worse. Not tonight's scroll. When you can stand the next truth, ask."

CHAPTER 45

TSUNARI

> *Thorne, Jeffrey. Listed lost. No body returned.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The disc is heavy glass in my hands. Uncatalogued. The lip of the case reads Ghost Beacon 09-Omega. Gideon gives me a loupe and stands back, which is how a curator shows he will not narrate a grief.

The etch is small. Mathematical shorthand along the margin. My father's hand. I know it the way I know the twist of the Bodkin. He listed things by counts. He did not waste a word. The company listed him lost. No body returned. The disc argues without raising its voice. A transmission from the far water. A hand that was still counting.

I do not say he is in the room. He is not in the room. The Cradle is not a place I let my mouth shape. The seed is the shorthand, and the seed is enough to make the floor feel dishonest.

"Ten years," I say.

"Received and unread by anyone who loved him," Gideon says. "I do not love him. I kept the glass. There is a difference."

Vram is in the doorway, wing low, giving me the privacy of not touching me yet. I want the touch and I want the minute. I put the loupe down. My eyes burn and I do not give the Vault the performance of a daughter collapsing.

"He sent this," I say. "That is the whole fact I am willing to hold. If I hold more, I will run at an ocean."

"Then hold the fact," Vram says.

I hold the disc until the cold of it is the same as the cold of the Bodkin at my skull. Listed lost. A hand that kept writing. I wrap the glass and I put it where the schedule skin already sits, two truths that refuse to stay rumors, and I walk back to the lamp before I ask Gideon what the next truth costs.

CHAPTER 46

TSUNARI

> *Five dishes on the bench. He counted them. He named one.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Gideon pricks my finger and does not apologize. A drop. The old spectrometer drinks it. The Vault's cryo-racks tick. Vram stands at my shoulder and does not touch the machine.

The light breaks.

Five crests on the far wall. One burns at the top, the body I have lived in since I was seventeen. Raptor. Under it, four quieter bands. He names them without a chart and without a job title. Avian. Lycan. Ceraton. Galvan. Dormant. Present. I feel the floor tilt the way it tilted for the shorthand, only this time the hand that did it is still the same man, and the hand was in my vein when I was a girl.

"He counted five dishes," I say. "He named one."

"He hid four in a daughter because a slide can be stolen and a girl who does not know her own inventory is harder to file." Gideon watches the crests, not my face. "You live in the Raptor. That one has no street name. The sleepers do. Hawk. Wolf. Rhino. Spark. You wear no collar. The shape can ground a leash. The socket stays in his neck. The fever stays his. If you came here for a cure that walks, you are in the wrong room."

Vram's jaw works. The socket is a fact between us. I look at the bright crest and the four sleeping ones and I stay the woman who held a jack in a door. I am also the place he put the rest.

"He wrote Keystone on the shape," Gideon says, almost gently. "Null-Resonance on the ground. A hand, aimed, on one soldier. You have been

doing it without the name."

"I didn't know."

"That was his mercy and his crime." He kills the lamp in the spectrometer. The crests die. The knowledge does not. "Sit down before you decide to be brave. Brave, in this room, is how a girl gets herself kept."

CHAPTER 47

VRAM

Gideon locks the lab. The stabilizer is his problem and not finished, and he says so through the door. The alcove is ours by the accident of a curtain.

I clean the burn on her shoulder. She watches my hands. The compact is already in my chest. The words are only a few days old. Partners, or nothing. I want the partners. The want has stopped pretending it is only the quiet.

"There isn't an empire of glass or gold that could buy your breath from my hands," I say. It comes out plain. I do not decorate it.

"Don't spend a speech if you mean a night," she says. Her fingers are at my belt. "Mean the night."

"I mean the night. And the morning. And the part where I stop if you say stop."

"Then don't stop yet."

We are slow because the yard was not slow. Mouth on her, her mouth on me, the heat a thing I govern instead of a thing that governs me. She tastes like copper and salt. I taste her until her hand fists in my hair and she tells me, clear, to come up. I come up. She takes me in with her eyes open. The wing curves around the cot, black feathers, a private wall. We move until the alcove is only breath and the sound she does not bother to hide. I follow her over and stay, shaking, the socket quiet because her palm is on my neck and because I would stay if it screamed.

After, she laughs once, wrecked, into my throat. I laugh into her hair. The laugh sits warm in my ribs.

Above us, in the vent, a body shifts. Caelia. I know the heat of an Ember the way I know a bad wind. She can see the feathers and the fact of us. She does not preach. A small radio crackles in her hand, the Forger's flat

voice, not meant for her and heard anyway. Bait. Disposable. If he will not take the right hand, spend the hand.

Caelia's breath breaks. She crawls back the way she came. I do not call out. Tsunari has heard the radio too. Her eyes are wet and furious and still soft on me.

"She'll break or she'll come back with a knife," she says.

"Let her choose in the hall," I say. "This room already chose."

CHAPTER 48

TSUNARI

> *All units, sync. The noise in your skull is the voice of your country. To quiet it is treason.*

❖ ❖ ❖

They corner him in the quartz hall with rifles that know his name.

Rook talks so the room cannot go holy. "If we're shooting the commander, I want it noted that my optics were dusty last time and somehow he lived. Suspicious."

Toby lowers his gun first. Cream and rust, the vane still split from the drone. He does not ask where his brother is. I do not tell him. Cassian is a silence I do not put in a boy's hands in a room full of triggers.

"Veda," I say. A woman with a socket and a tremor in the aim. "Ferrin. Look at me. I'm a hand. If you want the noise to stop for one minute, you say so. If you don't, you shoot and we find out what partners means."

Veda swears and nods. I put my palm on the side of her neck, beside the socket, and I aim. The tremor dies. Her eyes flood. She does not understand it. She believes it. Ferrin Calder, Rook when he is not performing, offers his throat like a joke that has run out. The same minute. The same quiet. I take my hands back. The quiet stays long enough for them to hear themselves.

Nothing leaves in a pocket. Gideon is still in the lab with a thing he will not call finished. The Ring does not get a mist tonight. Two soldiers get a minute. That is the whole charity.

Toby presses a small carved hawk into my palm. Quartz. Crude. "In case you forget you can fly," he says, gentle, wrecked. "It's a bird. Not a

claw. Don't make it weird."

"Too late," Rook says, and he turns his rifle toward the door the company will use.

The hall mutinies the way a hall mutinies, not with a song. With safeties and a choice. Vram looks at me over their heads. The order in their skulls is still treason. They make it anyway.

CHAPTER 49

VRAM

> **Two doors.** *The dome is coming down the sluices. The cult is coming up from the sump. The Vault is the room between.*

❖ ❖ ❖

I put my hand on the map Gideon will not let us take out of the room.

"Down," I say. "Corvus. Mechanized. They'll hose the lower sluices and call the dead a number."

"Up," Tsunari says. "Malakar. The Embers. They want the hall more than they want the doctrine, now that the doctrine spit them out."

The Vault sits between those two hungers. Quartz, paper, a curator with a pry bar he pretends is a walking stick. My wing is not on fire. The veins are veins. Whatever Gideon named in her blood, it has not turned me into a second sun. I am a man with a torn vane and a squad that just committed a crime for a minute of quiet.

"Toby on the upper drain," I say. "Rook with him. Veda on the stair. Boran will take a door if we ask him like a man and not like a flyer. Chen's steam, if she meant the promise."

"She meant the hours," Tsunari says. "Steam is a hour she can spend."

A boom, far, in the sluice. Another, closer, from the sump side. Two doors. One room. I roll the shoulder and the wing answers with pain, ordinary pain, the kind that does not rewrite a war.

"We hold," I say. "We don't chase a god down a pipe, and we don't fly into a hose. They have to come into the room we know."

She checks the hawk in her pocket, absurd and small, and nods. The next sound is boots. I go to meet them with the wing folded until I need it,

and I do not ask it to become anything but a wing.

CHAPTER 50

TSUNARI

> *Purge cleared. Hose the lower sluices. Civilian loss inside the numbers is acceptable. Bring the runners back dead or alive.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Chen's steam hits the landing like a wall that learned anger. The shock troops blind. They fire anyway. The order on their channel is plain. Civilian loss inside the numbers is acceptable. I hear it and I file the director who signed it under a name I already hate.

Boran plants himself in the hydraulic door. Hide, horn, the whole stubborn width of him. The flail hits the plate and the plate holds. He grunts. "Flyer, if you are going to help, help low. My face is busy."

Malakar comes through the steam at me, not at the door. The flail needs room and the threshold is a mistake for him and a gift. I am the gift he wants. Caelia comes out of the steam between us.

She does not preach. She puts her body on the arc. The iron takes her side with a sound I will hear when I am old, if I get to be old. Bone. She stays up long enough to shove me back through the seal.

"Shut it," she says. Blood in her teeth. "I heard what I was. Bait. I'm not bait."

I haul the door. Boran adds his weight. The seal bites. Malakar's roar cuts off under iron. Caelia slides down the inside of the door, breathing, broken, alive. I get my hands on the wound and I press.

"Don't you dare make it a hymn," I say.

She laughs, wet. "Too late. Tell him I chose the cold one. He'll hate that. Good."

Vram's shadow hits the steam on the far side of the grate. He sees her. He sees my hands. He does not have a speech either. The door holds. The order outside still wants us dead or in a bag. The woman on the floor wanted a god and spent herself on a person. I keep the pressure on, and I do not let her go into a story while she is still bleeding in this one.

CHAPTER 51

VRAM

> ***The gantry.*** *The crane spine above the Vault. Two men can meet on it. Only one of them needs the ground to win.*

❖ ❖ ❖

The roof is on fire in pieces. Drones. Cultists. The squad in the air, Hawks against machines, Toby the only Vance I can see and still not asking the question I will not answer.

Boran and Rook are back to back on a catwalk, insulting each other's bones while they break a squad that expected a sermon. "Hollow bird," Boran says. "Walking wall," Rook says. The flail is not with them. The flail is with Malakar, and Malakar is on the crane spine, and the spine is a place two men can meet.

I go up. The wing carries me and complains. I do not ask it for a miracle. A slug from somewhere friendly snaps a drone off my line. One slug. Then the gantry is boots and iron and his smile.

"Deliverer," he spits, making it dirt.

"Not yours."

The flail comes around. It needs room. The gantry gives him some and the drop gives him the rest. I beat once, short, and the weapon passes under the vane. We are not done. The veins in my neck are veins. The heat is the old heat. If there is a door in me past this, it stays shut while I still have a ordinary fight to win.

Below, Tsunari is a shape at the sluice with blood on her arms that might be Caelia's. She is not down. That is the only telemetry I trust.

Malakar comes again. I meet him on the spine, wing folding at the last moment so the flail hits rail instead of bone. The rail screams. We both stay on it. The sky can wait. The man cannot.

CHAPTER 52

DUAL POV

> *When the sky catches fire, the birds will fight for the dirt.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Vram

The gantry bucks. Malakar's flail kisses the rail beside my foot and the heat in me stops asking permission.

Black veins stand up at the neck, across the chest, in the soft skin beside the eyes. One vent. The wing dumps what it has been holding since the yard, a single ugly sunrise, and the flail slags in his hands. No title for it. No formula I could teach. It happens, and then I am empty, shaking, the veins sinking back to ordinary blood.

He stares at his ruined weapon and at me, and the faith tries to return and finds nothing to hold. I do not strike a kneeling man for a doctrine. I strike the hand that is still reaching for a knife. He goes over the side in the wash of a ruptured flume, into the dark water under the Vault. Whether he climbs out is not a fact I get tonight.

The sky is not on fire. The birds are on the dirt, which is the honest version of the line.

Tsunari

I reach the Forger while his light is still dying on the gantry.

She has the staff, iron, ritual, the thing she uses to point at people until they kneel. I do not kneel. The hook takes the shaft. The shaft breaks. The sound is small. Her power on this roof was the weapon and the story. The weapon is in two pieces. The story can chase me later.

"Cold Serpent," she says, and it sounds like a woman who has run out of congregation.

"Tsune," I say. "And you don't get the rest of my name."

Malakar's cry goes under the water and stays unfinished. I do not look long enough to bury him. Vram is on the spine, emptied, alive. Toby flashes past a drone and does not look for a brother. I will not put that death in the air while the roof is still choosing sides.

The staff is broken. I keep the pieces only long enough to throw them into the sluice. Let the water have the doctrine. I go up the spine for the man who vented and did not become her god.

CHAPTER 53

DUAL POV

> ***The salt flats.*** *West of the ring. The cult's road. People taken that way do not walk home.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Tsunari

Dawn on the scrubber roof. Smoke. Artificial stars dying in the shield-glow. Caelia breathes because I made her breathe, ugly work, not a hymn. Chen's people have the stills. The shelters will open when the freeze drops. The company has pulled back to count its acceptable losses. The cult has scattered into the pipes it came from.

Kira takes a sealed case from Gideon and a copy of the date. He tells her, in front of me, that the case is not a sky. She takes it anyway, because her road paid to know the fourteen months, and a locked box is a later argument. The Ring stays under the same lee. Sora stays inside the glass.

Vram sits on a sheared girder. The wing along it is black. Dawn hits one vane and throws obsidian, once, and the black takes it back. I sit with him. We cut the palms. A small hurt. We press them together, blood to blood, partners in a sentence that finally has witnesses who are just us.

"Nothing," he says.

"Or partners," I say, and I kiss him at dawn like a woman who intends to keep the morning.

The root opens on Gideon's bench because the Vault has the other half of the key and his hands are done being careful. The schedule we already heard. Fourteen months. The lee fails. The dome seals. Under that,

the line that would not open on the service door: when the sky is finished, the lower labs are a liquidation. Culture Lab 4. Sora Thorne. Marked.

I put my forehead on the girder until the want to run at the glass passes. Running does not open a dome. The name stays in my mouth. He does not make me say it twice.

Vram

We sleep in the bunker under the Vault because the roof is a target and the cot is a decision. Her hand on my chest. The compact drying on our palms. I think, for one hour, that the hour will hold.

The vapor comes in the vents, sweet, thick, a cult smell I know from the cistern and do not get to the door in time to stop. My knees go. Chains, real ones, bite the wrists. Hands drag. I hear her try to rise and fail. The salt is a word somebody says with reverence. West. The road people do not walk home from.

I try to vent. There is nothing left in the wing but a man's anger. They take me anyway.

Tsunari

I wake to cold sheet and a brand on the left shoulder, a chevron still smoking, their claim cut into skin. The hook is in my hand because some part of me did not sleep. He is not in the room. The vapor is a ghost. The west road is a fact.

I stand. The shoulder screams. The palm aches where his blood dried. I do not pray. I do not look at the sea. I look at the door, and I start walking, and the walking has his name under it and no permission to stop.

THE GOSPEL OF THE SLAG

> *The flesh is not a temple. It is the furnace. Whoever fears the hammer stays raw ore.*

❖ ❖ ❖

Three hundred feet under Sector 09, the basalt sweats.

Sister Maeva dips the bronze brand into the fissure. The metal comes up angry. She does not tour a cathedral. She does not name the parts of a pylon. She sets the brand to the inside of her thigh and holds it while the skin accepts the mark, a shepherd's crook split down the middle. Smoke. Her breath. Devotion with a cost she pays in person.

The rock hums. She does not go looking for the source. The hum is the amen.

They already have him. Chains. The salt road. West of the ring, where people do not walk home. She does not crown him here. A crown would be a comfort. The brand is the work.

She lifts the iron. The mark weeps. She smiles at the pain the way a woman smiles at a task finished correctly.

"The furnace keeps what it takes," she says, to the fissure, to the absent man, to the book that starts when the brand cools.

The hum answers. Sector 09 sleeps above her, and does not know the salt has already claimed a wing.

AUTHOR'S NOTE & ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

J.D. ALFARO

Building the shattered skies and scorched dunes of Arkun began with a simple question: what happens when two engineered survivors—each weaponized by trauma, duty, and genetic design—find salvation in the very touch they were taught to fear? Bringing Tsunari and Vram's story into the world has been an exhilarating, demanding, and deeply transformative voyage.

To my partner, Zuni: thank you for being my constant anchor, my first sounding board, and the quiet heart behind every word. Your faith in this world breathed life into it when the pages were dark. Every sentence carries the quiet imprint of your love.

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And finally, to you—the reader: thank you for walking the dangerous catwalks of Sector 09 with Tsunari and soaring through the storm with Vram. If this story stirred your pulse, kept you reading past midnight, or made your breath catch, then every late night and rewound line was worth it.

DID STOLEN BREATH STEAL YOURS?

★ ★ ★ ★ ★

Reviews are the lifeblood of independent authors. They help fellow romantasy and sci-fi readers discover new stories, support continuing series, and allow authors to keep creating the worlds you love.

If you enjoyed journeying with Tsunari and Vram, please take two minutes to **leave an honest review or rating on Amazon and Goodreads**.

Every star, every review, and every recommendation helps the rebellion rise. Thank you for your support!

THE ARKUN CYCLE • BOOK TWO

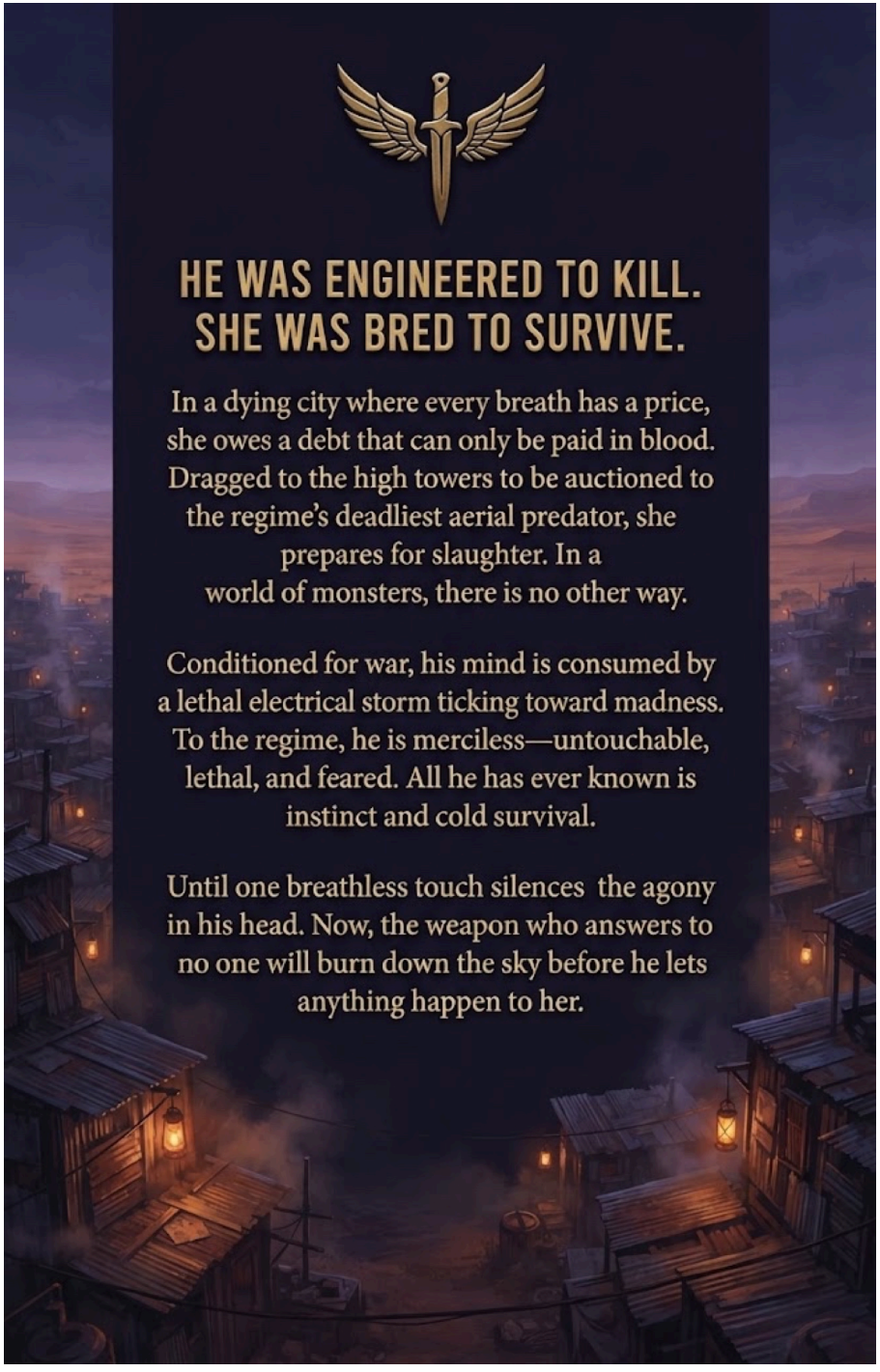
Crown of Salt

Coming Soon

> *"Fourteen months until outdoor air kills everything that breathes. Thirty days until the glass dome of Eden Alpha becomes Sora's tomb. And eighty miles of scorching, caustic salt between the hunter and the captive."*

THE ARKUN CYCLE WILL RETURN IN
BOOK TWO: CROWN OF SALT




HE WAS ENGINEERED TO KILL.
SHE WAS BRED TO SURVIVE.
In a dying city where every breath has a price, she owes a debt that can only be paid in blood. Dragged to the high towers to be auctioned to the regime's deadliest aerial predator, she prepares for slaughter. In a world of monsters, there is no other way.
Conditioned for war, his mind is consumed by a lethal electrical storm ticking toward madness. To the regime, he is merciless—untouchable, lethal, and feared. All he has ever known is instinct and cold survival.
Until one breathless touch silences the agony in his head. Now, the weapon who answers to no one will burn down the sky before he lets anything happen to her.